AN INTELLECTUAL & VISUAL HISTORY

How Brazil Became *Brazil*

Five centuries of geography, slavery, commodities, monarchy, migration and invention — told with Rio de Janeiro as a recurring protagonist.

Prologue · Five acts · Coda — about 50 minutes
Press → to advance, **N** for the deeper explanation behind any slide, **M** for sections.
Facts and contemporary data checked as of 24 October 2026.



Rafael Rabello de Barros, Rio de Janeiro from Corcovado: Botafogo, Sugarloaf and Gu..., 2011 · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

This presentation is built to be read at two levels. Each slide makes one argument visually and in a few sentences. The **deeper explanation** — this drawer — holds the reasoning, the evidence, the anecdotes and the scholarly disagreements, plus sources.

The organising question

How did Brazil become the country it is today, and why does Rio look, feel and function the way it does? The answer is built from a small number of forces that recur across five centuries: **geography** (a coast walled off by an escarpment, a giant interior reached by rivers), the **South Atlantic** (Brazil was assembled as much from Africa as from Portugal), **export cycles** that kept moving the economic centre of gravity, **slavery** as the operating system of society, and a political tradition of **elite accommodation** that changed regimes without changing hierarchies.

How to watch Rio

Rio is not a travel appendix. It returns whenever the city makes the national story physically visible: why the Portuguese chose Guanabara Bay, how gold made it the capital, what it meant for a European court to live there, where enslaved Africans landed, how the city was bulldozed into a Belle Époque capital, and why its mountains sort the classes. The final act turns all of this into a mental map of the city you are about to visit.

Cover image: Rio seen from Corcovado, with Botafogo, Sugarloaf and Guanabara Bay.

Brazil is the great *anomaly* of the Americas

Four facts that do not fit the familiar story of the New World.
Explaining them is the best way into Brazil.

I *country*

Where Spanish America became eighteen

Spain's American empire broke into 18 Spanish-speaking republics. Portuguese America stayed whole — and today covers 47% of South America.

4.9m *Africans*

The heart of the Atlantic slave trade

About 4.9 million enslaved Africans arrived alive in Brazil — roughly 45% of everyone carried across the Atlantic, twelve times the number landed in what became the United States.

1808 *–1821*

An empire governed from its colony

Fleeing Napoleon, the Portuguese crown moved to Rio. For 13 years a South American port was the capital of a European empire. Independence came under a Portuguese prince — as a monarchy that lasted until 1889.

1888

The last to abolish slavery

Brazil was the final country in the Western Hemisphere to end slavery — 23 years after the United States, and with no land, compensation or schooling for the freed.

THE QUESTION — How did Brazil become the country it is — and why does Rio look, feel and function the way it does?

Sources: SlaveVoyages estimates 1501–1866 (4.86m disembarked in Brazil of 10.7m total); IBGE; Fausto & Fausto (2014).

Each anomaly is a thread the presentation follows:

- **Unity and size** (Acts I–II): Brazil grew far beyond the line Portugal was granted in 1494, and then — against the regional pattern — did not fragment at independence. The explanation involves the 1808 transfer of the court, a slaveholding elite that feared disorder more than it wanted autonomy, and a good deal of force.
- **The slave trade** (Acts I–II): the SlaveVoyages consortium estimates about 12.5 million people embarked in Africa between 1501 and 1866, of whom about 10.7 million survived the crossing. Brazil received about 4.86 million; mainland North America about 389,000. Brazil's share is the single most important quantitative fact in its history.
- **The monarchy** (Act II): the Braganza court's move to Rio inverted the colonial relationship and made a negotiated, monarchical independence possible. Brazil was the only durable monarchy in post-colonial America.
- **Late abolition** (Act II): the institutional, economic and demographic reasons slavery survived to 1888 — and why abolition without reform left a long shadow.

"Eighteen republics" counts the sovereign Spanish-speaking states of the Americas: Mexico, Guatemala, Honduras, El Salvador, Nicaragua, Costa Rica, Panama, Cuba, the Dominican Republic, Colombia, Venezuela, Ecuador, Peru, Bolivia, Chile, Argentina, Uruguay and Paraguay. (Several broke away from each other after independence, and Uruguay was carved out of a war between Brazil and Argentina.)

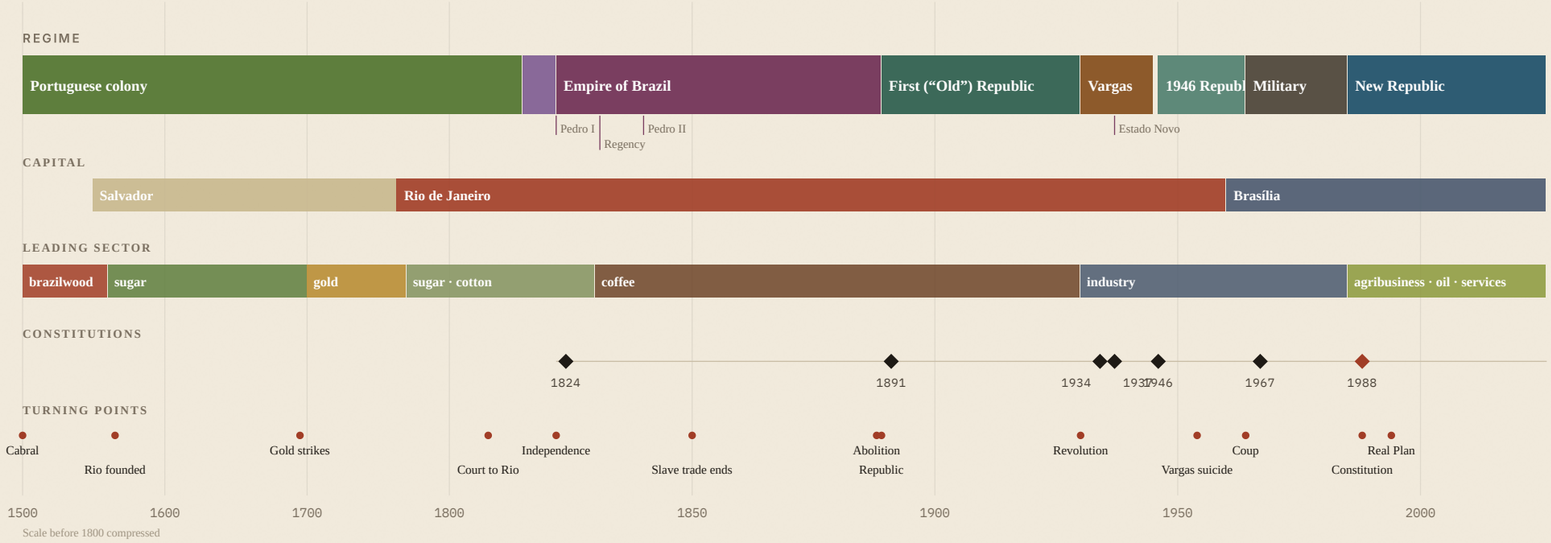
Brazil's area is about 8.5 million km²; South America's is about 17.8 million km².

SOURCES

1. SlaveVoyages consortium, Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database — Estimates, 1501–1866 (Emory University et al.). ↗
2. David Eltis & David Richardson, Atlas of the Transatlantic Slave Trade (Yale University Press, 2010).
3. Boris Fausto & Sergio Fausto, A Concise History of Brazil, 2nd ed. (Cambridge University Press, 2014).
4. IBGE, Censos Demográficos 1872–2022 (population of Brazil, municipalities of Rio de Janeiro and São Paulo; urban share). ↗

Colony, kingdom, empire, republics, dictatorships, democracy — *on one line*

Seven constitutions and three capitals. Note how each regime change coincides with a shift in what Brazil sold to the world.



The left third of the axis is compressed: three colonial centuries take up less room than the two centuries since 1808, because the pace of institutional change accelerates after the court arrives.

Reading the bands together

- **Regime and economy move together.** The Empire (1822–89) is the political shell of the coffee-and-slavery economy of the Paraíba valley; it falls within 18 months of abolition. The First Republic (1889–1930) is the political shell of São Paulo's immigrant-coffee economy; it falls in 1930, a year after the coffee price collapses. Vargas's state presides over import-substituting industrialisation; the military regime over the "miracle" and its debt; the New Republic over stabilisation and the commodity boom.
- **Capitals follow the centre of gravity — with a lag.** Salvador was the capital of sugar; Rio became capital in 1763 because it was the port of gold; Brasília (1960) was a deliberate attempt to move the centre of gravity inland ahead of the economy.
- **Constitutions are frequent; continuity is deeper.** Brazil has had seven constitutions (1824, 1891, 1934, 1937, 1946, 1967 — heavily amended in 1969 — and 1988), but many institutions survive across regimes: the labour code of 1943, the federal pact with powerful governors, a professional diplomatic service (Itamaraty), and an activist developmental state.

The "leading sector" band simplifies: sugar remained important through the 19th century, and the Amazon rubber boom (c. 1879–1912) briefly made rubber the second export after coffee. Dates for cycles are approximate.

SOURCES

1. Boris Fausto & Sergio Fausto, A Concise History of Brazil, 2nd ed. (Cambridge University Press, 2014).
2. Lilia M. Schwarcz & Heloisa M. Starling, Brazil: A Biography (Farrar, Straus & Giroux, 2018; orig. Brasil: Uma Biografia, 2015).
3. FGV CPDOC, Atlas Histórico do Brasil. ↗
4. IBGE, Estatísticas Históricas do Brasil, 2nd ed. (1990), incl. export shares by decade from the Anuário Estatístico do Brasil (1939/40); Recenseamento Geral do Império (1872).



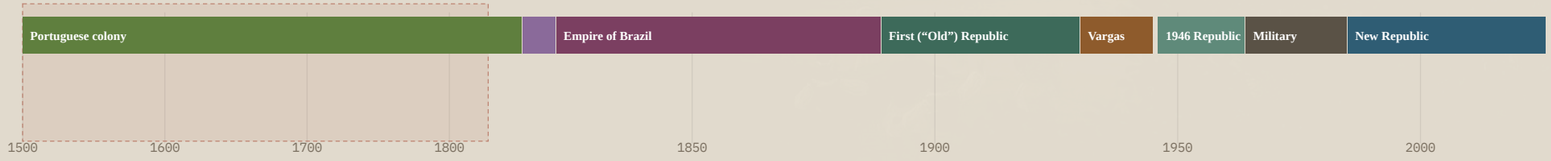
Frans Post, Landscape in Pernambuco, 17th c. · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act I

The Making of Colonial Brazil

c. 1500 – 1808

Why did a small European kingdom build a vast slave society in the tropics — and why did it keep pushing inland?



Act I explains the foundations: a geography that channelled settlement, the Indigenous societies the Portuguese encountered and destroyed, the Atlantic strategy of a small kingdom, the sugar plantation as an economic machine, the South Atlantic slave trade that fed it, the founding of Rio, and the gold rush that dragged the colony's centre of gravity south and made Rio its capital.

Image: Frans Post, *Landscape in Pernambuco* (17th century). Post travelled to Dutch-occupied Brazil in 1637 with Johan Maurits of Nassau-Siegen; his serene views of plantations and sugar mills — often with enslaved workers rendered as small figures — were painted largely after his return to Haarlem, for a European market hungry for images of the sugar colonies.

05 — GEOGRAPHY

A coast walled off from its interior — and rivers that ran *away* from the sea

1 The wall

Along the southeast, the Great Escarpment (Serra do Mar) rises 800–1,000 m within a few dozen kilometres of the shore. Good harbours behind it are rare — which is what made Guanabara Bay so valuable.

2 Rivers that point inland

Behind the wall, the Tietê flows west, away from São Paulo's coast, into the Paraná basin. It turned São Paulo into a launch pad for expeditions into the continent rather than a port.

3 Two Brazils by sea

Winds and currents made the north coast (Maranhão, Pará) easier to reach from Lisbon than from Salvador. Until the 1770s it was governed as a separate colony.



Shaded relief from AWS Terrain Tiles (SRTM/GMTED/ETOPO1); rivers: Natural Earth; escarpment and Tietê course drawn approximately.

Why geography is the right place to start. Brazil's colonial settlement hugged the coast for more than a century. Inland expansion followed a few gateways, and those gateways determined which cities mattered.

The escarpment and the harbours

From Santa Catarina to Espírito Santo the Brazilian Shield breaks off in the Great Escarpment. The Serra do Mar and, behind it, the Serra da Mantiqueira make the coastal strip narrow and the climb inland steep. For centuries goods moved up and down on mule trains (tropas). Natural harbours with sheltered deep water are scarce; Guanabara Bay — an enormous drowned river valley with a narrow mouth — is the outstanding exception, which is the geographic seed of Rio's importance.

The Tietê paradox

São Paulo sits on the plateau just behind the escarpment. Its river, the Tietê, runs not to the nearby sea but 1,100 km inland to the Paraná. Paulista expeditions — the bandeiras and later the river convoys (monções) to Cuiabá — used it as a highway into the interior. São Paulo was for two centuries a poor, Tupi-speaking frontier town whose wealth came from raiding Indigenous people and, eventually, finding gold. Its later dominance came only with coffee and railways.

Two colonies

In 1621 the Crown created a separate Estado do Maranhão (later Maranhão e Grão-Pará), governed directly from Lisbon, because sailing from São Luís or Belém to Salvador against the prevailing winds and currents could take longer than sailing to Portugal. It was merged into a single Brazilian administration only in the 1770s — one reason Pará initially sided with Lisbon in 1822–23.

The Northeast bulge

Cape São Roque, near Natal, is about 3,000 km from Dakar. Pernambuco and Bahia were the closest points of the Americas to both Portugal's sailing routes and West-Central Africa — the first reason sugar began there.

SOURCES

1. Celso Furtado, Formação Econômica do Brasil (1959); Eng. The Economic Growth of Brazil (1963).
2. John Hemming, Red Gold: The Conquest of the Brazilian Indians, 1500–1760 (Harvard University Press, 1978).
3. C. R. Boxer, The Portuguese Seaborne Empire, 1415–1825 (Hutchinson, 1969).
4. FGV CPDOC, Atlas Histórico do Brasil. ↗
5. Warren Dean, With Broadax and Firebrand: The Destruction of the Brazilian Atlantic Forest (University of California Press, 1995).



Albert Eckhout, Tupi man, 1643 · National Museum of Denmark · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons



Albert Eckhout, Tupi woman, 1641 · National Museum of Denmark · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons

06 — BEFORE 1500

Millions of people, not an empty forest

Portuguese ships met coastal Tupi-speaking peoples who had themselves recently expanded along the shore. Within a century, epidemics, war and enslavement had emptied much of the coast.

2–4m+

Plausible range for the population of what is now Brazil in 1500. Estimates are genuinely uncertain; Amazon floodplains were far more densely settled than once assumed.

1563

Smallpox and famine sweep the Jesuit villages of Bahia, killing tens of thousands — one reason planters turned to Africa for labour.

1.69m

Indigenous people counted in the 2022 census (0.8% of Brazil) — hundreds of peoples speaking well over 200 languages.

YOU WILL HEAR TUPI ALL OVER RIO

Guanabara — the bay

Carioca — a native of Rio (likely “white man’s house”)

Tijuca — “marsh, mud”

Ipanema — “bad / barren water”

Niterói — “hidden water”

Maracanã — a kind of macaw

Etymologies are traditional and some are disputed. **Copacabana** is the exception: the name comes from an Andean shrine to the Virgin of Copacabana on Lake Titicaca.

Paintings: Albert Eckhout, “Tupi man” and “Tupi woman”, 1641–43, painted in Dutch Brazil (National Museum of Denmark). Census: IBGE 2022.

Who lived here

In 1500 the coast from roughly São Paulo to the Amazon was dominated by Tupi-Guarani-speaking peoples — Tupinambá, Tupiniquim, Potiguar, Tamoio, Caeté and others — who lived in villages of several hundred people in large communal longhouses, grew manioc by swidden agriculture, fished, and waged chronic war between villages. Ritual execution and consumption of war captives was central to their social and religious life. It is documented by eyewitnesses with very different agendas — the German gunner Hans Staden, a captive in 1554–55; the Calvinist Jean de Léry; Jesuits such as Manuel da Nóbrega — and modern anthropologists treat it as real while reading the sources critically.

The interior was home to peoples the Portuguese lumped together as "Tapuia" (non-Tupi, often Macro-Jê speakers). In the Amazon, archaeology has transformed the picture: the Marajoara culture of Marajó Island (c. 400–1400 CE) built mound settlements and produced elaborate polychrome ceramics, and in the Upper Xingu researchers have mapped networks of fortified, planned settlements linked by roads, alongside anthropogenic "dark earths" (terra preta) that show long-term landscape engineering.

> **CONTESTED NUMBERS**
>
> Estimates of the Indigenous population of Brazil in 1500 range from about one million to five million or more. John Hemming's widely cited figure is about 2.4 million; higher estimates weight Amazonian archaeology more heavily. What is not in dispute is the scale of collapse: epidemics (smallpox, measles, influenza), enslavement and war killed a large majority within a few generations of contact on the coast.

Why it matters for what followed

- **Labour.** The first sugar mills used enslaved and coerced Indigenous workers. Epidemics (notably 1562–63), flight into a terrain the locals knew, Jesuit and Crown restrictions on enslavement (a 1570 law, repeatedly evaded) and Indigenous resistance pushed planters toward African captives.
- **Alliances.** Portuguese and French both depended on Indigenous allies. The founding of Rio was a war fought largely by Indigenous armies — the Temiminó leader Arariboia for the Portuguese, the Tamoio confederation for the French. Arariboia was rewarded with land across the bay: Niterói was founded in 1573 as his village.
- **Language and culture.** A Tupi-based *língua geral* was the everyday language of São Paulo and the Amazon well into the 18th century until the Marquis of Pombal mandated Portuguese. Manioc flour (farinha), the hammock (rede) and countless place names are Tupi legacies.

An intellectual surprise

In 1550 the city of Rouen staged a "Brazilian village" with some fifty Tupinambá for King Henri II. In 1562 Montaigne met three Tupinambá in Rouen; the encounter became "Of Cannibals" (1580), the essay in which he argued that Europeans, with their wars of religion, had little claim to call others barbarous. Brazil entered European thought as a mirror for Europe's own self-doubt.

Copacabana: the beach took its name from a chapel to Nossa Senhora de Copacabana, a devotion that originated at the shrine of Copacabana on Lake Titicaca (Bolivia).

SOURCES

1. John Hemming, Red Gold: The Conquest of the Brazilian Indians, 1500–1760 (Harvard University Press, 1978).
2. William M. Denevan (ed.), The Native Population of the Americas in 1492, 2nd ed. (University of Wisconsin Press, 1992).
3. Michael J. Heckenberger et al., "Pre-Columbian Urbanism, Anthropogenic Landscapes, and the Future of the Amazon," Science 321 (2008): 1214–17.
4. Eduardo Góes Neves, Sob os Tempos do Equinócio: Oito Mil Anos de História na Amazônia Central (Ubu/Edusp, 2022).
5. Hans Staden, Warhaftige Historia (Marburg, 1557); Jean de Léry, Histoire d'un voyage faict en la terre du Brésil (1578); Michel de Montaigne, "Des cannibales," Essais I.31 (1580).
6. IBGE, Censo Demográfico 2022: Identificação étnico-racial; Indígenas; Favelas e Comunidades Urbanas (releases 2023–24).

07 — PORTUGAL'S ATLANTIC

A small kingdom found Brazil *on the way to India*

Portugal had perhaps 1–1.5 million people. Its fortune lay in Asian spices, and Brazil was a by-product: Cabral's India fleet swung far west to catch the South Atlantic winds and struck the coast in April 1500.

For thirty years the only business was **brazilwood**, a red dye-wood (brasa = ember) that gave the land its name. Only French interlopers forced the Crown to settle — first by handing coastal strips to private "donatários" (1534), then by founding a royal capital at Salvador (1549).

The template already existed on the Atlantic islands: **Madeira** proved sugar; **São Tomé** proved sugar worked by enslaved Africans.



The Cantino planisphere, 1502 — smuggled from Lisbon to Italy. It already shows the Tordesillas line and a Brazilian coast decorated with parrots and trees.



Map: author's reconstruction on shaded relief. Cantino map: Biblioteca Estense, Modena (public domain).

Why Portugal, and why so thinly?

Portugal was a small, poor kingdom on Europe's Atlantic edge with a precocious maritime state. From the 1410s it pushed down the African coast for gold, captives and a sea route to Asia; Vasco da Gama reached India in 1498. Pedro Álvares Cabral's second India fleet (13 ships) made landfall near Porto Seguro on 22 April 1500. Whether the landfall was accidental or intentional is an old debate; most historians see it as the natural consequence of the wide westward arc (the *volta do mar*) needed to use the South Atlantic trade winds, and note that Portugal had insisted in 1494 on moving the demarcation line far enough west to cover any land there.

Tordesillas (1494)

Spain and Portugal divided the non-Christian world along a meridian 370 leagues west of the Cape Verde islands. Because the league and the starting island were never fixed, the line's position was contested — cartographers placed it anywhere from about 42°W to 50°W; Brazilian textbooks conventionally draw it from near Belém to Laguna (about 48–49°W), as on these maps. On any reading, most of present-day Brazil lies west of it. How Brazil came to occupy that territory is a theme of the following slides.

Brazilwood and the French

The first three decades were a dye-wood trade carried on through coastal trading posts with Indigenous labour paid in tools and trinkets; in 1502 the Crown leased it to a consortium led by Fernão de Noronha. French traders from Normandy competed vigorously and allied with coastal peoples. To secure the coast the Crown in 1534 divided it into hereditary captaincies granted to private donatários who had to finance colonisation themselves. Most failed; Pernambuco (Duarte Coelho) and São Vicente prospered on sugar. In 1549 the Crown sent a governor-general, Tomé de Sousa, with the first Jesuits, to found Salvador.

A pattern that recurs

A Crown short of money and people delegated the costs and the profits of expansion to private actors — donatários, planters, merchants, bandeirantes — in exchange for loyalty and a share of revenue. Historians from Raymundo Faoro to Stuart Schwartz have debated whether this created a centralised "patrimonial" state or a weak state captured by local elites; arguably it created both: a state formally centralised but dependent on bargains with powerful private interests.

SOURCES

1. C. R. Boxer, The Portuguese Seaborne Empire, 1415–1825 (Hutchinson, 1969).
2. Boris Fausto & Sergio Fausto, A Concise History of Brazil, 2nd ed. (Cambridge University Press, 2014).
3. Stuart B. Schwartz, Sugar Plantations in the Formation of Brazilian Society: Bahia, 1550–1835 (Cambridge University Press, 1985).
4. John Hemming, Red Gold: The Conquest of the Brazilian Indians, 1500–1760 (Harvard University Press, 1978).

Sugar made Brazil a business — and the business ran on *enslaved Africans*

INPUTS

Land
Huge royal grants (sesmarias) on fertile massapê clay near rivers & ports

Enslaved labour
Africans bought on credit; 18-hour shifts in the 8–9 month harvest

Firewood & oxen
Furnaces consumed forests; Atlantic forest cleared mile by mile

Credit
Merchants advanced captives & goods against the next crop

Cane fields
Planters & tenant cane growers (lavradores) who milled at the master's engenho and split the sugar.

→

The mill
Water- or ox-driven rollers crush the cane within hours of cutting — the factory sets the pace.

→

Boiling house
Juice is boiled through a row of copper kettles: the most dangerous, most skilled work.

→

Purging house
Clay-topped conical moulds drain molasses, yielding white and brown (mascavo) sugar.

→

Port & ship
Crates (caixas) shipped from Salvador & Recife to Lisbon and Porto — and on to Amsterdam & Antwerp.

→

Europe
Dutch & Flemish refiners and distributors captured much of the value; Brazil exported raw sugar.

↓ Molasses → cachaça → traded in Angola for captives

WHERE THE SURPLUS WENT

Crown	Merchants & creditors	European refiners	Planter class
tithe & duties	interest, slave sales, freight	refining & distribution margin	land, status, and more slaves

Shares are schematic, not measured — they show who had claims on the crop, not exact proportions.

> *"The slaves are the hands and the feet of the sugar-mill owner."*
>
> André João Antonil (the Jesuit Giovanni Antonio Andreoni), *Cultura e Opulência do Brasil*, 1711 — a planter's manual the Crown suppressed for revealing too much about colonial wealth.

By around 1600 Brazil was the world's largest sugar producer. The engenho was a **factory in a field**: capital-intensive, time-critical and dependent on a labour force that could be driven without limit. Status followed: "to be a senhor de engenho," wrote Antonil, "is a title to which many aspire."

Why sugar, why the Northeast

Sugar was the most valuable agricultural commodity in early modern Europe. Pernambuco and Bahia's Recôncavo had the right soils (dark massapê clays), rainfall, rivers for transport and water power, and the shortest sailing times to Europe and Africa. The Portuguese brought the technology and the labour model from Madeira and São Tomé.

The economics of the mill

Cane must be crushed within a day or two of cutting, so the mill imposed an industrial rhythm on agriculture. A large engenho needed heavy investment — rollers, copper kettles, buildings, oxen, boats, and above all scores or hundreds of enslaved workers — which is why credit networks linking planters to merchants in Salvador, Recife, Lisbon and Amsterdam were essential. Many cane farmers (*lavradores de cana*) did not own mills; they brought cane to the master's engenho and typically received about half the sugar it yielded, a relationship of dependence that made the senhor de engenho a local lord.

Why African rather than Indigenous labour

Stuart Schwartz's classic account shows a transition between about 1570 and 1620. Indigenous workers died in epidemics, fled into a terrain they knew, and were protected (inconsistently) by Jesuits and royal law. Africans were already available through Portuguese trading posts in West-Central Africa, some came from societies with agricultural and iron-working skills that planters valued, and — crucially — merchants could finance their purchase. Planters paid two to three times more for an African than for an Indigenous captive, a price difference that reflects productivity expectations and survival rates, not benevolence.

> INTERPRETATION
>
> Caio Prado Jr. (1942) argued that the "meaning of colonisation" was to supply Europe with tropical goods, so that colonial society was organised from outside. Later historians (e.g. João Fragoso, Manolo Florentino) stressed that much colonial wealth was accumulated and reinvested inside Brazil, by Brazilian merchants, especially in the slave trade. Both are true at different scales: the export sector set the rhythm, but the profits of trafficking and credit stayed substantially in Rio and Salvador.

The Dutch interlude (1630–1654)

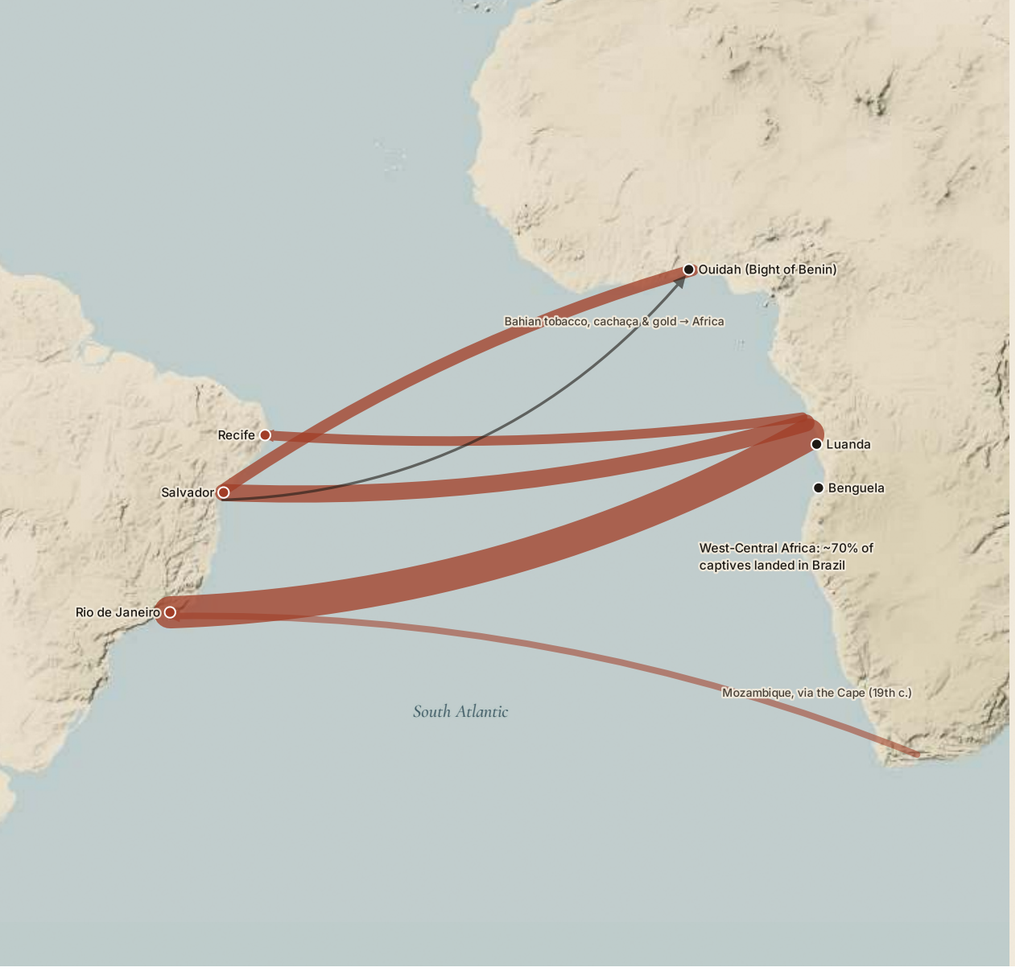
The Dutch West India Company seized Pernambuco in 1630; under Johan Maurits of Nassau-Siegen (1637–44) Recife became a cosmopolitan town with a synagogue — the first in the Americas — and artists such as Frans Post and Albert Eckhout. Luso-Brazilian planters, many indebted to Dutch creditors, rebelled; victories at Guararapes (1648–49) — later mythologised as the birth of Brazilian nationhood — led to Dutch surrender in 1654. Expelled Dutch and Sephardic Jewish planters and merchants helped spread the sugar complex to the Caribbean, and Caribbean competition eroded Brazil's dominance after the 1650s.

Resistance: Palmares

From about 1605 to 1694 the quilombo (maroon community) of Palmares in the hills of Alagoas sheltered thousands of escaped enslaved people. Repeated Dutch and Portuguese expeditions failed until paulista mercenaries under Domingos Jorge Velho destroyed it; its leader Zumbi was killed on 20 November 1695. That date is now the Day of Zumbi and Black Consciousness, a national holiday since 2024.

SOURCES

1. Stuart B. Schwartz, Sugar Plantations in the Formation of Brazilian Society: Bahia, 1550–1835 (Cambridge University Press, 1985).
2. Celso Furtado, Formação Econômica do Brasil (1959); Eng. The Economic Growth of Brazil (1963).
3. Caio Prado Jr., Formação do Brasil Contemporâneo (1942) — the classic statement that colonial Brazil existed to supply Europe.
4. Luiz Felipe de Alencastro, O Trato dos Viventes: Formação do Brasil no Atlântico Sul (Companhia das Letras, 2000); Eng. trans. The Trade in the Living (SUNY Press, 2018).
5. C. R. Boxer, The Portuguese Seaborne Empire, 1415–1825 (Hutchinson, 1969).

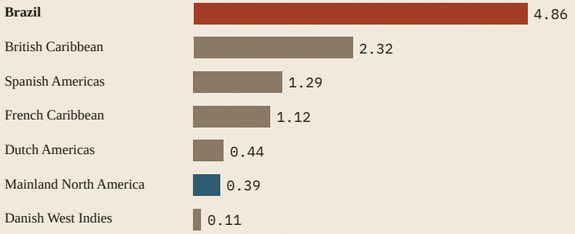


09 — THE SOUTH ATLANTIC SYSTEM

Brazil was built from the *South Atlantic*, not just from Europe

Winds and currents made Angola and Brazil a natural circuit. Ships owned in Rio and Salvador sailed direct to Africa with cachaça, tobacco and gold, and returned with captives — a bilateral trade that often bypassed Lisbon entirely.

ENSLAVED AFRICANS LANDED ALIVE, 1501–1866 (MILLIONS)



WITHIN BRAZIL



About 12.5 million people were embarked in Africa; some 1.8 million died at sea. In 1648 an expedition *from Rio* retook Luanda from the Dutch — Rio's merchants needed Angola.

Data: SlaveVoyages, Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database estimates (rounded). Flow widths are schematic.

Scale

The SlaveVoyages estimates (Eltis, Richardson and collaborators) put total embarkations from Africa at about 12.5 million (1501–1866) and arrivals at about 10.7 million. Brazil received about 4.86 million — roughly 45%. Within Brazil, the Southeast (essentially Rio de Janeiro) received the most, about 2.3 million, most of them in the 18th and 19th centuries; Bahia about 1.5 million; Pernambuco about 0.85 million. Recent research suggests Rio was the single largest slave-trading port in the Americas.

The South Atlantic as one system

Luiz Felipe de Alencastro's *O Trato dos Viventes* argues that Brazil was "formed outside Brazil": the colony's economy and society were constituted in a South Atlantic space that joined Portuguese America to Angola. The ocean's clockwise gyre made voyages between Luanda and Rio or Salvador relatively quick and predictable. Brazilian goods — Bahian tobacco (prized on the Bight of Benin), cachaça (jeribita) in Angola, later gold and textiles — paid for captives. Brazilian-based merchants dominated the trade by the 18th century; some, like the great Rio traffickers of the early 19th century, were among the richest men in the Empire.

Africa was not passive in this system: African states and merchants controlled the supply of captives in the interior, and the trade reshaped African politics, from the Kingdom of Kongo and Ndongo to Dahomey and Oyo.

The 1648 expedition

When the Dutch occupied Luanda (1641–48), sugar planters in Brazil lost their labour supply. Salvador Correia de Sá, governor of Rio de Janeiro, organised and largely financed from Rio a fleet that retook Luanda in 1648. It is a striking illustration of the argument: the defence of Angola was a Brazilian interest.

Cultural consequences

Bantu-speaking West-Central Africans (from Kongo, Ndongo, Benguela) predominated in Rio and the Southeast; West Africans from the Bight of Benin (Yoruba, Fon/Gbe, Hausa) were especially numerous in 19th-century Bahia, where they shaped Candomblé and led the 1835 Malê uprising. Many Brazilian words — samba, quilombo, moleque, caçula, cafuné — have Bantu origins.

SOURCES

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Brazil received twelve times more Africans than the United States — and ended with *fewer* enslaved people

Two mechanisms explain the paradox, and together they shaped modern Brazil's racial order:

1. Death outpaced birth. Plantations and port cities killed enslaved people faster than they could reproduce; the captives imported were mostly young men. While the trade was open, owners replenished by purchase. The US enslaved population, by contrast, grew by natural increase after its trade ended in 1808.

2. Manumission was common. Many enslaved Brazilians — especially women and city dwellers — bought or were granted freedom. By 1872 free people of African descent outnumbered both the enslaved and the white population.

The result was not a two-caste society but a **graded colour hierarchy**, with a large free population of colour — and slavery nonetheless intact.



Brazil 1872 also counted 0.39m "caboclos" (of Indigenous descent). Total population 9.93m.

Sources: SlaveVoyages estimates (arrivals); US Census 1860; Recenseamento Geral do Império, 1872 (IBGE). Free Black & pardo = pretos + pardos counted minus enslaved.

The numbers

About 389,000 enslaved Africans landed in mainland North America; by 1860 the US had about 3.95 million enslaved people and 0.49 million free Black people. About 4.86 million landed in Brazil; the first national census (1872) counted 1.51 million enslaved people among 9.93 million inhabitants, alongside 3.79 million whites, 3.80 million pardos (mixed) and 1.95 million pretos (Black) — of whom, once the enslaved are subtracted, about 4.25 million were free people of African descent.

Why mortality was so high

Sugar work, tropical disease in crowded ports, poor nutrition and brutal discipline produced high death rates; skewed sex ratios (often around two men for every woman among arrivals) and low fertility meant the enslaved population could not reproduce itself. Herbert Klein and Francisco Vidal Luna stress that this pattern varied by region and period: in some 19th-century coffee areas, and among creole (Brazilian-born) populations, natural growth was possible. The general rule held while cheap captives were available: reproduction was not where owners invested.

Manumission — and what it did and did not mean

Brazilian law and custom allowed enslaved people to purchase freedom (often in instalments) and owners to free individuals, frequently in wills. Freed people and their descendants could own property — including slaves. This created a large free population of colour and a society of fine colour gradations rather than the binary "one-drop" rule of the US South.

CONTESTED INTERPRETATION

Frank Tannenbaum (1946) and Gilberto Freyre argued that Iberian law and Catholicism made Brazilian slavery milder. Since the 1960s historians have largely rejected this: mortality was higher in Brazil, and manumission functioned as an incentive that reinforced control, often freeing the old or the favoured while the system as a whole intensified. The debate matters because the "mild slavery" idea fed the later myth of racial democracy (see Act III).

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Rio was founded to keep the French out — on a bay built for defence

Guanabara is a vast, sheltered, deep-water bay behind a narrow entrance — rare on a coast walled by mountains. In 1555 the French got there first: Nicolas de Villegaignon founded **“France Antarctique”** on an island in the bay, allied with the Tamoio peoples.

The Portuguese answered with Jesuit diplomacy, Indigenous allies and force. Estácio de Sá founded São Sebastião do Rio de Janeiro on **1 March 1565** at the foot of Sugarloaf; after his death from an arrow wound, the city was moved to a defensible hilltop — Morro do Castelo — in 1567.



“La France Antarctique, autrement le Rio Ianeiro” — a French map after the voyages of Villegaignon and Jean de Léry (1557–58). The name means “River of January”: the bay was reportedly taken for a river mouth on 1 January 1502.



Map: shaded relief (AWS Terrain Tiles) with IBGE coastline; site positions approximate.

The site

Guanabara Bay is a drowned river valley about 30 km deep from mouth to head, studded with islands and fed by rivers draining the Serra do Mar. It offered what the escarpment coast lacked: anchorage protected from Atlantic swell, a mouth narrow enough to cover with artillery (the forts of Santa Cruz on the Niterói side and São João/Urca on the Rio side still stand), fresh water (the Carioca river), timber, and Indigenous villages to trade with. Its drawback — a narrow strip of flat land between granite hills, swamps and the water — has shaped the city ever since.

France Antarctique (1555–1567)

Nicolas Durand de Villegaignon, a Knight of Malta with Huguenot backers including Admiral Coligny, built Fort Coligny on the island that now bears his name. The colony mixed Catholics and Calvinists (Geneva sent pastors; Jean de Léry's account is a classic of ethnography) and quarrelled itself apart over theology. The French relied on the Tupinambá/Tamoio, who were themselves at war with Portuguese-allied peoples.

The Portuguese response

Governor-general Mem de Sá destroyed Fort Coligny in 1560 but lacked men to hold the bay. The Jesuits Manuel da Nóbrega and José de Anchieta negotiated the Peace of Iperoig (1563) with part of the Tamoio confederation. Mem de Sá's nephew, Estácio de Sá, established a fortified camp between Sugarloaf and the Cara de Cão hill on 1 March 1565 — the city's official founding — and fought for two years with Temiminó allies under Arariboia. He was wounded by an arrow in the decisive battle of January 1567 and died weeks later. The city moved to Morro do Castelo, whose summit held the Jesuit college, the cathedral and the fort.

The hill that is gone

Over the next century the town crept down from the hill onto the flat strip by the water — the Rua Direita (now Rua Primeiro de Março) and what became Praça XV. Morro do Castelo itself was demolished in 1920–22, partly for sanitation and partly to clear space for the 1922 Centennial Exposition. When you stand in the Esplanada do Castelo you are standing where Rio's founders lived, at the level of the hill's base.

The 1 January 1502 naming story is traditional; the exact date and expedition (often attributed to Gaspar de Lemos, possibly with Amerigo Vespucci) are uncertain.

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Gold dragged Brazil south and inland — and made Rio the capital

São Paulo’s slave-raiding expeditions found gold in the 1690s in what became Minas Gerais. The result was the largest gold rush the world had yet seen: hundreds of thousands of Portuguese migrants and enslaved Africans poured inland.

The fastest route to the sea ran to **Rio**. The Caminho Novo turned a modest port into the colony’s main outlet for gold and its main market for slaves, and in **1763** the capital moved from Salvador to Rio.

Colonial Brazil’s population grew roughly tenfold over the century, to about 3 million.



Raquel Mendes Silva, Ouro Preto, historic centre, 2014 · CC BY-SA 4.0 · Wikimedia Commons

Ouro Preto (Vila Rica): baroque churches built on gold. Routes drawn approximately after FGV Atlas Histórico.



Bandeirantes

The paulistas who found the gold were the bandeirantes — frontiersmen, often of mixed Portuguese-Indigenous descent and Tupi-speaking, whose expeditions (bandeiras) hunted Indigenous captives across the interior. In 1628–31 they destroyed the Jesuit missions of Guairá, enslaving tens of thousands of Guarani. São Paulo later celebrated them as heroic pathfinders (the enormous Monument to the Bandeiras in Ibirapuera Park dates from 1953); today their legacy is fiercely contested.

The rush

Strikes around Ouro Preto, Mariana and Sabará from the mid-1690s set off a rush that depopulated parts of Portugal and the sugar coast. The newcomers (emboabas) fought the paulistas in the War of the Emboabas (1707–09); the defeated paulistas pushed further west and found gold in Cuiabá (1719) and Goiás (1720s). Diamonds were found near Diamantina in the 1720s; the Crown made the district a closely policed monopoly.

CONTESTED NUMBERS

How much gold? Registered output (subject to the royal fifth, the *quinto*, collected at royal smelting houses) peaked around the 1730s–1750s. Virgílio Noya Pinto's estimates imply roughly 800–1,000 tonnes over the century, with heavy smuggling making any figure a floor. The once-popular claim that Brazilian gold "financed the Industrial Revolution" is overstated; it certainly flowed in large quantities through Lisbon to London under the 1703 Methuen Treaty trade, strengthening Britain's monetary base and trade balance.

Why the capital moved

By the mid-18th century Rio handled gold exports, slave imports for Minas, and the provisioning of the mining towns, and it was the military key to the contested southern frontier with Spain (the Colônia do Sacramento on the River Plate). The transfer of the viceroy's seat from Salvador to Rio in 1763 recognised that the colony's centre of gravity had moved south.

Gold and rebellion

As output fell, the Crown's demands did not. The threat of a *derrama* — a forced levy to cover arrears in the gold tax — prompted the Inconfidência Mineira (1789), a conspiracy of Minas elites inspired partly by the American Revolution. It was betrayed; the one conspirator of modest status, the militia ensign Joaquim José da Silva Xavier, "Tiradentes," was hanged in Rio on 21 April 1792. The Republic later made him a national martyr; 21 April is a national holiday, and Brasília was inaugurated on that date in 1960.

What you can see in Rio

Gold financed the gilded interiors of Rio's colonial churches — the Mosteiro de São Bento and the Igreja de São Francisco da Penitência are among the most spectacular — and the Carioca Aqueduct (the Arcos da Lapa), completed around 1750 to bring water to a city that gold had made populous.

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The centre of gravity kept moving — *and Brazil followed it*

2020s

Brasília, soy, and offshore oil

A planned inland capital (1960), an agribusiness frontier across the Cerrado, and deep-water “pre-salt” oil off Rio and São Paulo. But people and money remain concentrated in the southeast.

CAPITAL
Brasília

SCALE
Population 203 million (2022 census)

Press → to step through six moments. Dashed outline: today’s borders, for orientation. Zones are schematic.

This map makes one argument: **each export cycle created a new core region, and political power followed the money with a lag**. Old cores did not disappear; they became the regions with the deepest inequality and the most entrenched elites.

- **c. 1570.** Settlement was coastal and discontinuous. Each captaincy faced the sea.
- **c. 1650.** The sugar Northeast is the economic heart; Salvador is the capital. The Dutch period shows how contested the coast was. Paulista bandeiras push inland, ignoring Tordesillas, mostly to capture Indigenous people.
- **c. 1760.** Gold relocates the economy to Minas Gerais and the capital to Rio (1763). Portuguese diplomacy — led by the Brazilian-born Alexandre de Gusmão — wins the Treaty of Madrid (1750), which replaced Tordesillas with the principle that land belongs to whoever effectively occupies it. Gusmão used maps that, conveniently, understated how far west Portuguese settlements lay. Later treaties (1761, 1777) partly unwound Madrid, but the broad outline held.
- **c. 1860.** Coffee, grown by enslaved Africans in the Paraíba valley between Rio and São Paulo, is the Empire's economic base. The sugar Northeast declines relatively; it begins exporting enslaved people south through an internal slave trade after 1850.
- **c. 1920.** The coffee frontier has moved into western São Paulo along railways; immigrants replace enslaved workers. São Paulo becomes the industrial centre. The Amazon rubber boom (c. 1879–1912) made Manaus briefly one of the richest cities in the Americas until Asian plantations, grown from seeds taken from Brazil in 1876, undercut it. The Baron of Rio Branco's diplomacy settled almost all remaining borders by negotiation and arbitration, including the purchase of Acre from Bolivia (Treaty of Petrópolis, 1903).
- **Today.** Brasília (1960) and the agricultural conquest of the Cerrado — made possible by Embrapa's soil science from the 1970s — moved activity into the Centre-West. Offshore "pre-salt" oil since 2006 has made the Southeast coast an energy province. Yet the Southeast still holds about 42% of the population and roughly half of GDP.

Population estimates before 1872 are reconstructions with wide margins (Indigenous people outside colonial society were rarely counted).

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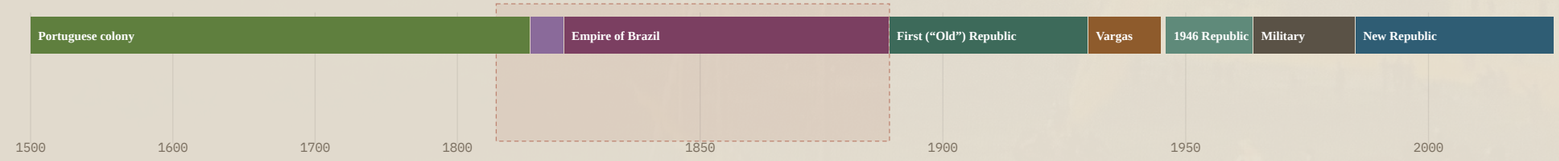
Nicolas-Antoine Taunay, View of Glória beach and church, Rio, 1816–17 · Museu Nacional de Belas Artes · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act II

An Empire in the Tropics

1808 – 1889

Why did Brazil become an independent monarchy rather than a republic — and why did it hold on to slavery longer than anyone else?



Act II runs from the arrival of the Portuguese court in Rio (1808) to the fall of the monarchy (1889). It is the period when Brazil acquired its territorial unity, its political class, its capital-city culture, and the coffee-and-slavery economy that underwrote the Empire.

Image: Nicolas-Antoine Taunay, *View of Glória beach and church* (1816–17). Taunay came with the French Artistic Mission of 1816. The baroque church of Nossa Senhora da Glória do Outeiro (1739) still crowns its hill above the Aterro do Flamengo — but the beach in the painting is gone, buried by 20th-century landfill.

A European empire came to be governed *from its colony*

In November 1807, as Napoleon’s army closed on Lisbon, the Prince Regent João sailed for Brazil under British naval escort with the royal family, the government and thousands of courtiers. In March 1808 they landed in Rio.

A colonial port became an imperial capital almost overnight. Its population roughly doubled in about a decade; the colony’s ports were opened to foreign — above all British — trade, ending three centuries of Portuguese monopoly.

CREATED IN RIO BY THE COURT — MOST STILL EXIST

- 1808 Banco do Brasil
- 1808 Botanical Garden
- 1810 Military Academy
- 1808 Royal Press & first newspaper
- 1810 Royal Library (now Biblioteca Nacional)
- 1816 French Artistic Mission → Academy of Fine Arts



Jean-Baptiste Debret, Acclamation of King João VI in Rio de Janeiro, 1818, 1834 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Debret, the acclamation of João VI, Rio, 6 February 1818 — staged at the Paço on what is now Praça XV, the only time a reigning European monarch was acclaimed in the Americas.

1815
Brazil raised to a kingdom co-equal with Portugal

1820
Liberals in Porto, furious at being “a colony of a colony,” demand the king’s return

Dates: Wilcken (2004); Schultz (2001). Court size is contested — see notes.

Why the court moved

Portugal was trapped between Napoleon's Continental System and its old alliance with Britain. When French troops under Junot marched on Lisbon in November 1807, the Regent João (his mother, Queen Maria I, was mentally ill) carried out a plan discussed for decades: move the seat of the monarchy to Brazil, the empire's richest part. The fleet left on 29 November 1807, escorted by the Royal Navy; Britain's price was commercial access.

> CONTESTED NUMBERS
>
> The court is traditionally said to have brought 10,000–15,000 people. Nireu Cavalcanti and others argue from ship capacities and passenger lists that the figure was far smaller — perhaps a few thousand. Either way, the newcomers were a large, privileged and demanding minority in a city of perhaps 50,000–60,000.

What changed in Rio

- **Housing.** Officials requisitioned the best houses under the right of *aposentadoria*, marking doors "P.R." (Príncipe Regente) — which cariocas read as "Ponha-se na Rua" ("Get out into the street").
- **The palace.** The court occupied the viceroy's palace (the Paço, Praça XV) and then the Quinta da Boa Vista in São Cristóvão — donated by Elias Antônio Lopes, a merchant enriched by the slave trade. The palace later became the National Museum, devastated by fire in 2018.
- **Institutions.** A bank, a press (printing had been banned in the colony), libraries, academies, a botanical garden where the imperial palms descend from a single "palma mater" planted by João in 1809.
- **Trade.** The 1808 opening of the ports and the 1810 treaty with Britain — which gave British goods a 15% tariff, lower than Portugal's own 16% — made Rio a commercial hub tied to London.

The inversion

In December 1815 Brazil became a kingdom within the United Kingdom of Portugal, Brazil and the Algarves. Portuguese at home now complained that Portugal had become a dependency of its colony. The Liberal Revolution in Porto (1820) demanded a constitution and the king's return. João VI left in April 1821, reportedly advising his son Pedro to take the Brazilian crown himself rather than let "some adventurer" do it — a remark that may be apocryphal but captures the logic of what followed.

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Pedro Américo, Independência ou Morte! (The Cry of Ipiranga), 1888 · Museu Paulista, USP · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Pedro Américo, *Independência ou Morte!* (1888) — painted 66 years after the event as national myth. Witnesses suggest the prince, suffering from an upset stomach, was riding a mule.

16 —— 1821–1825

Independence came as a *dynastic split*, not a revolution

When Lisbon's new parliament tried to reverse Rio's status, Brazil's elites rallied around the heir who had stayed behind. On 7 September 1822 Pedro declared independence near São Paulo; in December he was crowned Emperor in Rio. Portugal recognised it in 1825 — after Britain brokered a deal in which Brazil took over £2 million of Portuguese debt.

It was not bloodless — there was real fighting in Bahia, Maranhão and Pará — but the state, the dynasty and the social order survived intact.

WHY THE TWO EMPIRES ENDED SO DIFFERENTLY

Spanish America

1808: Napoleon captures the Spanish king. Legitimacy collapses; local juntas, civil wars (1810–25). Four viceroyalties and many audiencias become 18 republics.

Portuguese America

1808: the king escapes to Rio with the state. One court, one treasury, one army — and an heir in place to claim the whole territory as a single empire.

Slaveholding elites also wanted continuity: a monarchy promised order at a time when Haiti's revolution (1791–1804) haunted every plantation society.

Barman (1988); Carvalho, A Construção da Ordem; Fausto & Fausto (2014).

The sequence

- **1820–21:** The Porto revolution convenes the Cortes in Lisbon; João VI returns (April 1821), leaving Pedro as regent.
- **Late 1821:** The Cortes order Pedro home and begin dismantling the institutions created in Rio — which Brazilian elites read as "recolonisation."
- **9 January 1822 — the "Fico":** petitioned by Rio, São Paulo and Minas notables, Pedro announces he will stay.
- **7 September 1822:** on the banks of the Ipiranga stream near São Paulo, receiving dispatches from Lisbon, Pedro declares "Independence or death."
- **12 October / 1 December 1822:** acclaimed and then crowned Emperor in Rio.
- **1823:** Portuguese garrisons expelled from Salvador (2 July — still Bahia's great civic holiday), São Luís and Belém, with help from the British mercenary admiral Thomas Cochrane.
- **1825:** Treaty of Rio de Janeiro, mediated by Britain: Portugal recognises independence; Brazil assumes Portuguese debt (about £1.4m to British creditors plus compensation to João VI, about £2m in all). Britain, in return, extracts a treaty (1826–27) committing Brazil to end the slave trade.

Why a monarchy?

José Murilo de Carvalho's influential answer stresses the elite: Brazil's ruling class was small, trained largely at Coimbra in law, and socialised into royal service. It saw the Braganza heir as the guarantor of unity, order and property — above all property in people. A republic risked regional fragmentation and popular mobilisation, and the Haitian Revolution made slaveholders fearful of both. The dynasty also offered legitimacy that no Brazilian strongman possessed.

The constitution of 1824 — imposed by Pedro after he dissolved an elected constituent assembly — created a "moderating power" (inspired by Benjamin Constant) that let the emperor appoint ministers, dissolve the Chamber and choose senators for life from three-name lists. It lasted until 1889, longer than any Brazilian constitution since.

The painting

Pedro Américo's canvas was commissioned for the Museu Paulista in São Paulo and finished in Florence in 1888. It gives the prince a heroic white horse and dragoons in dress uniform; accounts by members of the party suggest a smaller, dustier scene. It is a superb document — of how the late Empire wanted its founding remembered.

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Unity was not destiny: the Empire had to *hold* Brazil together



After Pedro I abdicated in 1831, leaving a five-year-old heir, a decade of regency nearly broke the country apart. Uruguay did break away. Historians weigh several explanations for why the rest held:

An elite of one mould

Coimbra-trained magistrates and bureaucrats rotated across provinces, forming a national ruling class.

Fear as glue

Provincial slaveholders needed a strong central army against slave revolt — as Salvador's Malê uprising (1835) showed.

A crown worth joining

Rio's court distributed titles, offices and credit; the 1840 coronation of the 14-year-old Pedro II restored a symbol of unity.

Force

The army and National Guard, under commanders like Caxias, crushed revolts one by one.

Carvalho, A Construção da Ordem; Barman (1988). Locations approximate.

Brazil's territorial unity is often presented as inevitable. It was not. The 1830s saw revolts in almost every corner, with very different social bases:

- **Cabanagem (Pará, 1835–40)** — the most radical: poor mestiços, Indigenous people and freed slaves briefly seized Belém. Repression and fighting killed perhaps 30,000–40,000 people, a large share of the province's population (estimates vary widely).
- **Farroupilha (Rio Grande do Sul, 1835–45)** — a ranchers' revolt over taxes on jerked beef that declared an independent republic and lasted a decade. It ended in negotiated amnesty, not defeat. Giuseppe Garibaldi fought for it.
- **Revolt of the Malês (Salvador, 1835)** — a carefully planned uprising led by Muslim enslaved and freed Africans, mostly Yoruba (Nagô) and Hausa. It was suppressed within hours, but it terrified slaveholders across Brazil.
- **Sabinada (Salvador, 1837–38)** and **Balaiada (Maranhão, 1838–41)**, and in Pernambuco the republican revolts of 1817, the Confederation of the Equator (1824) and the Praieira (1848).
- **Cisplatina** — the territory (today's Uruguay) annexed by Portugal in 1821 rebelled, Argentina intervened, and after a stalemated war Britain mediated the creation of an independent Uruguay in 1828.

COMPETING EXPLANATIONS

José Murilo de Carvalho emphasises elite homogeneity and the state's capacity to train and circulate a national elite. Others stress slavery: decentralisation was attractive in theory, but regional elites recoiled from the social upheaval that separatist wars could unleash. Ilmar Rohloff de Mattos highlights how the Rio-based conservative coalition (the "Saquaremas") built a centralised order after 1837 in alliance with the coffee planters of the Paraíba valley. Military force was decisive in specific cases. These are complementary rather than exclusive — but contingency mattered: had the Farroupilha won foreign backing, or the regency lasted longer, the map might look different.

Pedro II

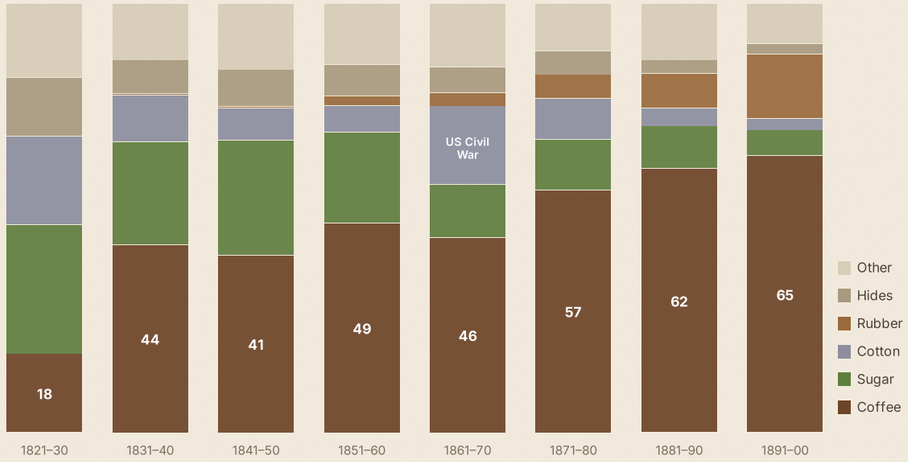
Liberals engineered the early declaration of Pedro II's majority in 1840. He reigned for 49 years: bookish, scientifically curious (he corresponded with Pasteur, met Graham Bell at the 1876 Philadelphia exhibition), personally austere, and the pivot of a parliamentary system in which he used the moderating power to rotate Conservatives and Liberals in office. Stability under him was real — and inseparable from the slave economy that financed it.

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Coffee rebuilt the economy around Rio — on the last great wave of the slave trade

SHARE OF BRAZIL'S EXPORT EARNINGS BY DECADE (%)



Export shares: IBGE, Estatísticas Históricas do Brasil (from Anuário Estatístico 1939/40), as reproduced in Fausto & Fausto. Arrivals: SlaveVoyages estimates.



Marc Ferrez, Enslaved workers on a coffee fazenda, Paraíba valley, c. 1885 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Marc Ferrez, c. 1885: enslaved workers on a coffee fazenda in the Paraíba valley, three years before abolition.

Coffee climbed from the hills of Rio up the **Paraíba valley** from the 1820s. It was planted by enslaved Africans: roughly **2 million** captives landed in Brazil in 1801–1850, more than in any earlier half-century — most of them through Rio, and much of it illegally after a ban of 1831 that was passed, as the phrase went, *"para inglês ver"* — for the English to see.

From Tijuca to the Paraíba

Coffee arrived in Pará in the 1720s (the story that Francisco de Melo Palheta obtained seedlings in French Guiana through a liaison with the governor's wife is a cherished legend), and was grown in the hills around Rio — including the slopes of Tijuca — by the late 18th century. With collapsing Haitian production after 1791 and growing demand in the US and Europe, it spread from the 1820s along the Paraíba do Sul valley through Vassouras, Valença and Bananal. The planters who grew rich there — the "coffee barons," many ennobled by Pedro II with non-hereditary titles — were the backbone of the Empire's Conservative party.

The economics

Coffee needed land, cheap transport to the coast and, above all, labour. Forest was cleared by fire; soils were exhausted within a generation or two and planting moved on. Coffee went to Rio on mule trains, then on the Dom Pedro II railway (1858). The labour was enslaved: Rio's great traffickers supplied the valley, and the trade surged as coffee boomed. Historians (Dale Tomich, Rafael Marquese) call this the **"second slavery"**: a 19th-century intensification of slavery tied to industrial-era commodities — Cuban sugar, US cotton, Brazilian coffee — rather than a survival of the old colonial order.

The illegal trade

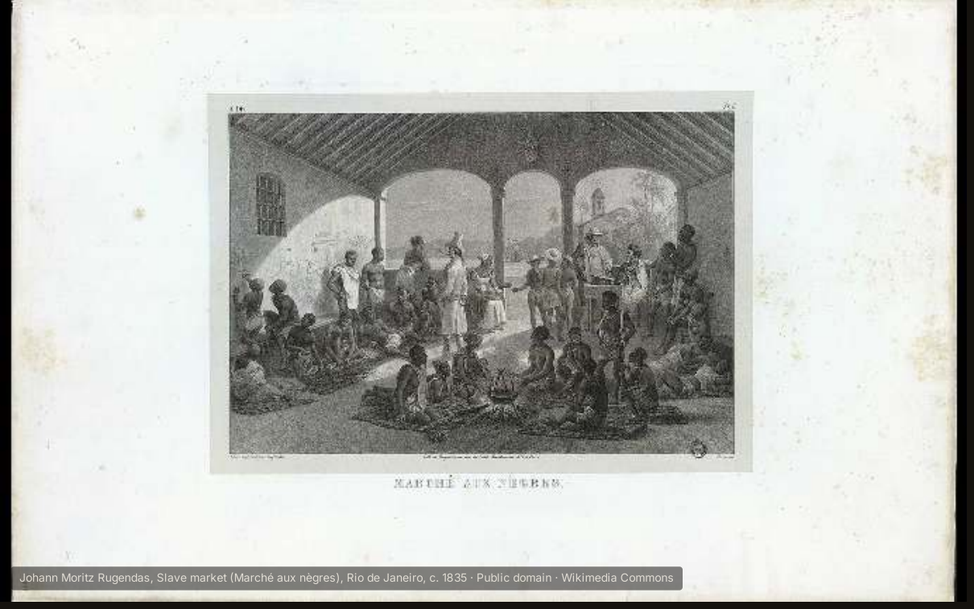
An 1831 law declared the trade illegal and Africans landed thereafter free; it was flagrantly ignored. Between 1831 and 1850 several hundred thousand Africans — the best estimates exceed 700,000 — were smuggled into Brazil and held as slaves illegally, a fact abolitionists like Luís Gama later used in court to win freedom for individuals. British pressure culminated in the Aberdeen Act (1845), under which the Royal Navy seized Brazilian slavers, eventually even in Brazilian waters. In 1850 the Eusébio de Queirós law, this time enforced, ended the Atlantic trade.

Export structure

The chart shows the rise of coffee from about 18% of export earnings in the 1820s to about 65% in the 1890s. Note the spike in cotton during the US Civil War, when Union blockade cut off Confederate cotton, and the rise of Amazon rubber in the 1890s. Brazil became the world's largest coffee producer in the 1840s and has remained so ever since.

SOURCES

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3. SlaveVoyages consortium, Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database — Estimates, 1501–1866 (Emory University et al.). ↗
4. Leslie Bethell, The Abolition of the Brazilian Slave Trade (Cambridge University Press, 1970).
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Johann Moritz Rugendas, Slave market (Marché aux nègres), Rio de Janeiro, c. 1835 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons



Halley Pacheco de Oliveira, Valongo and Empress wharfs, archaeological site, 2012 · CC BY-SA 3.0 · Wikimedia Commons



Felipe Restrepo Acosta, Pedra do Sal, 2018 · CC BY-SA 4.0 · Wikimedia Commons

19 —— RIO · VALONGO, 1770S–1831

The largest slave port in the Americas — buried, and rediscovered

In the 1770s the viceroy moved Rio's slave market from the centre to **Valongo**, a cove just beyond the city, to keep the sick and dying newly arrived out of sight. A wharf was built in 1811. UNESCO estimates that some **900,000** enslaved Africans were landed through the Valongo complex — warehouses, a quarantine house, and a cemetery for those who died on arrival.

In 1843 the wharf was paved over for the arrival of an empress; in the 1900s it vanished under landfill. Excavations for the 2016 Olympics found it again in 2011. It became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2017.

41%

of Rio's 266,466 people were enslaved in the 1849 census — the largest urban slave population in the Americas

WHEN YOU GO

Valongo Wharf → Instituto Pretos Novos (the cemetery, on Rua Pedro Ernesto) → Pedra do Sal (right): a 15-minute walk through "Little Africa."

Top: Rugendas, *Marché aux nègres* (Rua do Valongo), 1835. UNESCO WHC 1548; 1849 census (Karasch 1987).

The Valongo complex

Until the 1770s captives were sold in the Rua Direita near the palace (today's Rua Primeiro de Março). The Marquis of Lavradio moved the market to the Valongo cove on hygienic and moral grounds: the sight of emaciated arrivals was thought to spread disease and offend. What grew up there was an industrial-scale reception system: shops (armazéns) where captives were fattened, shaved and oiled for sale — the scene in Rugendas' and Debret's images — a lazaretto, and the **Cemitério dos Pretos Novos** ("cemetery of new blacks"), where perhaps tens of thousands of people who died soon after arrival were dumped in shallow pits and burned. It was rediscovered in 1996 when a family renovating their house in Gamboa found bones; the Instituto Pretos Novos now operates there.

Burial by landfill

The stone wharf (Cais do Valongo) was built in 1811. In 1843 it was overlaid by a more elegant landing stage, the Cais da Imperatriz, to receive Teresa Cristina of Bourbon-Two Sicilies, Pedro II's bride. The port works of 1904–11 (Passos era) pushed the shoreline out by hundreds of metres and buried both. During the Porto Maravilha redevelopment in 2011, archaeologists led by Tânia Andrade Lima exposed both pavements and recovered hundreds of thousands of objects — amulets, cowries, pipes, beads — the material culture of the people who came ashore here.

How big was Rio's trade?

UNESCO's inscription estimates that some 900,000 Africans arrived through Valongo; other estimates for the city as a whole range up to around 2 million over the full history of the trade, which would make Rio the largest single slave port in the history of the Atlantic world. The exact figure depends on how illegal post-1831 landings, often made on beaches outside the city, are counted.

The slave city

The 1849 census of the Corte counted 266,466 inhabitants, 110,602 of them enslaved. Mary Karasch's classic study shows a city whose streets were run by enslaved labour: *escravos de ganho* hired out by their owners as porters, water carriers, barbers, vendors and musicians, keeping a share of earnings; women selling food (quitandeiras); Bantu-speaking communities with their own brotherhoods, healers and fighting arts. Capoeira was a persistent concern of the police and was criminalised in the 1890 Penal Code.

Pequena África

After abolition, migrants from Bahia and freed people settled the cheap rooming houses of Saúde, Gamboa and the area around Pedra do Sal — the neighbourhoods later called "Little Africa." Pedra do Sal, a rock outcrop with steps carved into it where salt was once unloaded, is now the site of crowded Monday-night samba sessions. The story continues in Act III.

SOURCES

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5. SlaveVoyages consortium, Trans-Atlantic Slave Trade Database — Estimates, 1501–1866 (Emory University et al.). ↗

Slavery was not so much abolished as *slowly strangled* — and the freed received nothing

1831	Trade banned — and ignored
1850	Atlantic trade ends (British pressure)
1850	Land Law: land only by purchase
1871	Free Womb Law
1880s	Abolitionist movement; mass flights
1884	Ceará and Amazonas abolish
1885	Sexagenarian Law
13 May 1888	Lei Áurea: unconditional abolition

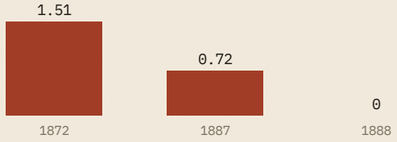
THE ENTIRE GOLDEN LAW

Art. 1. Slavery in Brazil is declared extinct from the date of this law.
Art. 2. All provisions to the contrary are revoked.



13 May 1888, Paço Imperial (Praça XV): crowds outside the palace as Princess Isabel signs the law, in Pedro II's absence abroad.

ENSLAVED POPULATION (MILLIONS)



No compensation to owners — and none to the freed: no land, no schooling, no wages guaranteed. Many planters turned republican overnight.

Census 1872; 1887 slave registry (matrícula). Conrad (1972); Machado (1994).

Why so late?

Slavery was everywhere in Brazilian society — not just plantations but cities, small farms, the households of modest families, even freed people. Coffee profits in the Paraíba valley depended on it, and the planters of Rio, Minas and São Paulo dominated the Empire's Conservative governments. Without a civil war or a foreign occupation to force the issue, abolition proceeded by gradual laws designed to manage the transition on owners' terms.

The stages

- **1850 — end of the trade.** After the Royal Navy began seizing slavers in Brazilian ports, the government enforced the Eusébio de Queirós law. Prices of enslaved people rose sharply, and an internal trade moved perhaps 200,000 people from the Northeast and the South to the coffee regions.
- **1850 — the Land Law** (passed two weeks later): public land could henceforth be acquired only by purchase, not by occupation. Combined with the end of the trade, it was designed to keep future free workers — immigrants and freedpeople — from becoming independent smallholders. Compare the US Homestead Act of 1862.
- **1871 — Free Womb (Rio Branco) Law:** children born to enslaved mothers were free, but owners could keep their labour until age 21.
- **1880s — mobilisation.** Joaquim Nabuco, André Rebouças (a Black engineer), José do Patrocínio (a Black journalist) and Luís Gama — born free in Bahia, sold into slavery by his father, self-taught lawyer who won freedom in court for hundreds — led a genuinely popular movement. Ceará's jangadeiros (raft fishermen) refused to carry captives south (1881); Ceará and Amazonas abolished slavery in 1884.
- **1885 — Sexagenarian Law:** freed people over 60 — after three more years of "compensatory" labour.
- **1887–88 — collapse.** In São Paulo enslaved people fled plantations en masse, helped by abolitionist networks (the caifazes); the army's officers asked not to be used to hunt fugitives. The system was disintegrating before the law caught up with it.

13 May 1888

The Lei Áurea, signed by Princess Isabel as regent at the Paço Imperial, consisted of two articles. Rio celebrated for days; an open-air mass at São Cristóvão on 17 May drew an enormous crowd (photographs survive). In Leblon, the abolitionist José de Seixas Magalhães had sheltered fugitives in a **quilombo** where camellias were grown — the camellia became the movement's badge.

Joaquim Nabuco had warned in 1883 that slavery would long remain "the national characteristic of Brazil": its effects would outlast its legal abolition. The absence of land reform, education or any transitional support, together with the state's subsidy of European immigration (Act III), shaped racial inequality for the following century.

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Benedito Calixto, Proclamation of the Republic, 1893 · Pinacoteca do Estado de São Paulo · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

21 —— 15 NOVEMBER 1889

The Republic arrived as a military coup the public barely noticed

The monarchy fell within 18 months of abolition. It had lost the **planters** (no compensation), the **Church** (a clash over Freemasonry in the 1870s), and the **army**, whose officers — veterans of the Paraguayan War, steeped in Comte's positivism — resented civilian politicians. São Paulo's coffee elite wanted federal autonomy. Marshal Deodoro, a monarchist, led the troops. The emperor sailed into exile two days later.

> *"The people watched it all stupefied, astonished, surprised, without knowing what it meant. Many sincerely believed they were watching a parade."*
>
> Aristides Lobo, a republican, 18 November 1889

Six days earlier the court had held its last great ball on **Ilha Fiscal**, the neo-Gothic customs island in the bay. The flag's motto, **Ordem e Progresso**, is Comte's.

Painting: Benedito Calixto, *Proclamação da República*, 1893 (Pinacoteca de São Paulo). Carvalho, Os Bestializados (1987).

Why the monarchy fell

- **The Paraguayan War (1864–70)**, fought by Brazil, Argentina and Uruguay against Paraguay, was the bloodiest interstate war in South American history. It built a professional officer corps with grievances against the politicians who ran the Empire, and recruited enslaved men who were promised freedom. Paraguay's losses were catastrophic (estimates of the share of its population killed vary widely and remain debated).
- **Positivism.** Young officers trained at the Military School of Praia Vermelha absorbed Auguste Comte's doctrine of scientific, authoritarian progress through their teacher Benjamin Constant Botelho de Magalhães. "Order and Progress" on the flag is the positivist motto.
- **The Religious Question (1872–75)**: the imprisonment of two bishops who had acted against Freemasons alienated the Church.
- **Abolition without compensation** turned many slaveholders into "13th of May republicans."
- **São Paulo.** The Paulista Republican Party (founded 1873) represented western coffee planters who wanted to control their own taxes, railways and immigration policy — which a federal republic would give them.
- **Succession.** The heir, Isabel, was a woman, devoutly Catholic and married to a French prince (the Count d'Eu) who was unpopular; few relished a Third Reign.

On the morning of 15 November 1889 troops gathered at the Campo de Santana (now Praça da República) and Deodoro forced the cabinet out; a republic was proclaimed that afternoon at Rio's city council. The imperial family sailed for Europe on 17 November. Pedro II died in Paris in 1891.

The "bestialised" people

José Murilo de Carvalho took Aristides Lobo's word — *bestializado* — as the title of a classic book arguing that the Republic was made without, and largely against, the people of Rio: the new regime restricted the vote to literate men (a small minority), and the city's popular classes had little stake in it. Ironically the monarchy, with Pedro II and Isabel "the Redeemer," had been popular among freed people in Rio.

See it in Rio

Ilha Fiscal (visits by the Navy's cultural centre from the Espaço Cultural da Marinha near Praça XV); the Campo de Santana park, opposite Central do Brasil; and the Catete Palace, which became the presidential residence in 1897.

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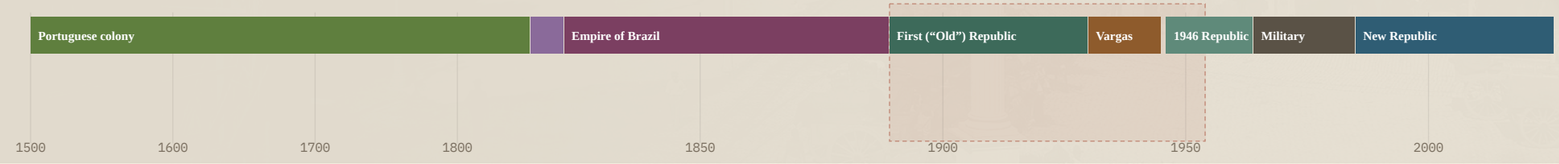
Marc Ferrez, Avenida Central (now Rio Branco), c. 1906 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act III

The Creation of Modern Brazil

1889 – 1954

How did a coffee republic run by a few thousand voters become an urban, industrial, mass society — and who was let in?

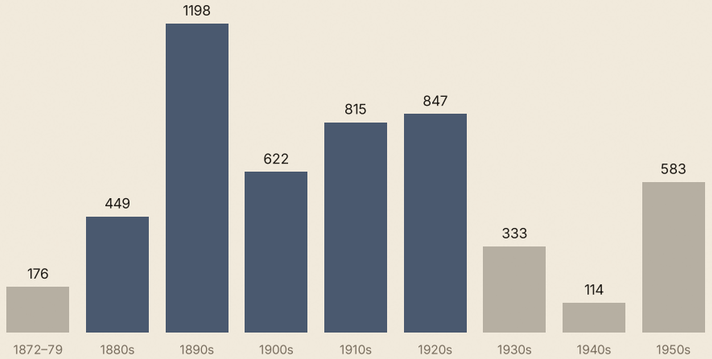


Act III covers the First Republic (1889–1930), the transformation of Rio into a Belle Époque capital, and the Vargas era (1930–1954), which built the modern Brazilian state and — alongside radio, samba and football — a modern national identity.

Image: Avenida Central (today Avenida Rio Branco), photographed by Marc Ferrez around 1906, shortly after it was driven through the colonial centre. Almost none of these façades survive: the avenue was rebuilt again with towers from the 1940s onward. The Theatro Municipal, the National Library and the Museum of Fine Arts at its southern end (Cinelândia) are the survivors.

A federation of coffee oligarchs chose European immigrants over Brazil's own freed people

IMMIGRANTS ARRIVING IN BRAZIL, BY DECADE (THOUSANDS)



Mostly Italians, Portuguese and Spaniards; Japanese from 1908. São Paulo paid many passages.

Canudos, 1896–97

The army destroyed a religious community of backlanders in Bahia led by Antônio Conselheiro — estimates run up to 25,000 people — killing most of its defenders. Returning soldiers settled on a Rio hillside they nicknamed **Morro da Favella** — see slide 25.

Immigration: IBGE / Levy (1974), entries by decade. Holloway (1980); Skidmore, Black into White (1974); Leal (1949).



"To Brazil! Free passage" — 1886 poster recruiting Italian families for São Paulo's coffee farms, where they replaced enslaved labour under the *colonato* system.

An 1890 decree opened Brazil to immigrants — except "natives of Asia and Africa," who needed Congress's approval. Elites spoke openly of **"whitening"** the nation.

Politics was a pact of state oligarchies — São Paulo and Minas above all — resting on local bosses (*coronéis*) who delivered votes. Before 1930 no presidential election drew votes from more than about 6% of the population.

Who ruled

The 1891 constitution created a federal republic with powerful states that taxed their own exports, raised their own militias and ran their own elections. President Campos Sales (1898–1902) formalised the "politics of the governors": the federal government supported each state's dominant oligarchy; in return the state delivered loyal congressional delegations. At the base sat the **coronel** — a landowner, often holding a National Guard title, who controlled the votes of dependants (Victor Nunes Leal's *Coronelismo, Enxada e Voto*, 1949, remains the classic analysis). Literacy requirements excluded most adults; fraud did the rest. The presidency often alternated between São Paulo and Minas Gerais — the "café com leite" pact — though historians now stress that the arrangement was less stable and more contested than the label implies.

Coffee policy as industrial policy

With coffee prices falling from overproduction, the coffee states agreed at Taubaté (1906) to buy and stockpile surplus coffee, financed by foreign loans — a commodity cartel run by the state. Brazil supplied the majority of the world's coffee in this period, giving it unusual market power, and these "valorisation" schemes recurred until the 1930s. They established a long-lasting habit: the state as manager of producer interests.

Immigration and whitening

Some 4 million immigrants arrived between 1880 and 1930. São Paulo's government (via the Sociedade Promotora de Imigração, 1886) subsidised family passages and received migrants at the Hospedaria dos Imigrantes before dispatching them to coffee estates. Planters preferred Europeans partly because families were thought more stable and controllable — and partly for openly racial reasons.

Elite thinkers combined scientific racism with an optimistic twist: miscegenation plus European immigration would "whiten" Brazil (Thomas Skidmore's *Black into White*; Lilia Schwarcz's *O Espetáculo das Raças*). Decree 528 (1890) required congressional authorisation for immigrants from Africa and Asia. Japanese immigration began in 1908 (the *Kasato Maru*); Brazil now has the largest population of Japanese descent outside Japan.

The consequence for freed people was severe: excluded from the best rural jobs in the most dynamic region, many moved to cities and to informal work. Florestan Fernandes later argued that abolition "threw the Black population into the free labour market" without preparation or protection.

Canudos

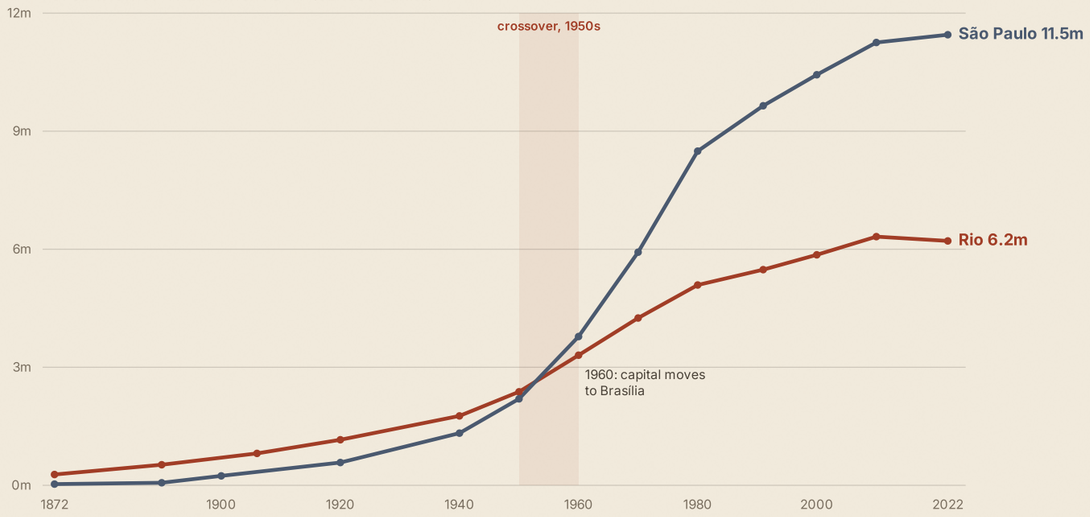
In the Bahian backlands, the preacher Antônio Conselheiro gathered a large community at Canudos. The new Republic saw monarchist subversion; three expeditions were defeated before a fourth, with artillery, destroyed it in October 1897. Euclides da Cunha's *Os Sertões* (1902) — part reportage, part scientific racism, part tragedy — made it a founding text of Brazilian literature.

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Rio stayed the capital — but coffee money made *São Paulo* the engine

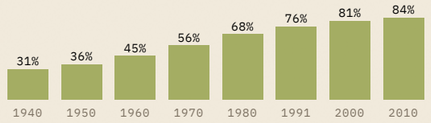
POPULATION OF THE MUNICIPALITY (CENSUS YEARS)



In 1872 São Paulo was a provincial town of 31,000. Its rise came from the coffee frontier to its west and three advantages Rio lacked: a **British railway** down the escarpment to Santos (1867), **immigrant wage-earners** who formed a consumer market, and planters who reinvested in **industry** and hydroelectric power.

Rio kept politics, the navy, finance, the press and culture — until 1960.

BRAZIL'S URBAN SHARE



IBGE censuses 1872–2022 (Rio: Município Neutro / Distrito Federal / Guanabara / município; 1906 Rio census). Urban share: IBGE.

Why São Paulo?

Western São Paulo's red soils (*terra roxa*) were ideal for coffee. The São Paulo Railway (1867), a British-built cable-hauled line up the Serra do Mar, linked the plateau to the port of Santos; Paulista planters then financed a dense network of railways into the interior. Wage-earning immigrant families spent money, creating a market for textiles, food processing and construction materials; immigrant entrepreneurs (the Matarazzos, Crespis) and planter families reinvested coffee profits. The Canadian-owned São Paulo Light (1899) and its hydroelectric projects supplied cheap power. By the mid-20th century São Paulo state accounted for the largest share of national industrial output — a position it retains.

What Rio kept

As federal capital, Rio concentrated government, the diplomatic corps, the armed forces, the national press and radio, the largest stock exchange until the 1970s, and an outsized share of the country's intellectual and artistic life. Its economy rested on public employment, services, commerce and the port — which is why the loss of the capital in 1960, and the merger of the city-state of Guanabara into Rio de Janeiro state in 1975, hit it so hard.

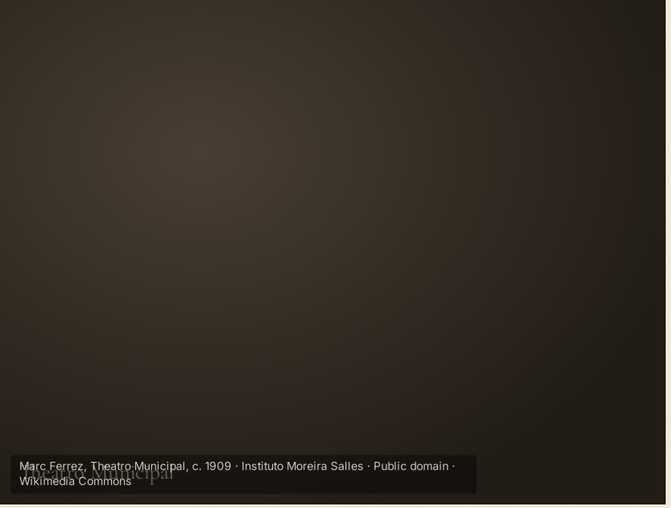
Data note

Figures are for the municipality (the city proper), not the metropolitan region; today greater São Paulo has about 21 million people and greater Rio about 12–13 million. Rio's figure for the early 1900s uses the 1906 municipal census. Rio's 2022 census count (6.21 million) was slightly below 2010 — the first decline recorded.

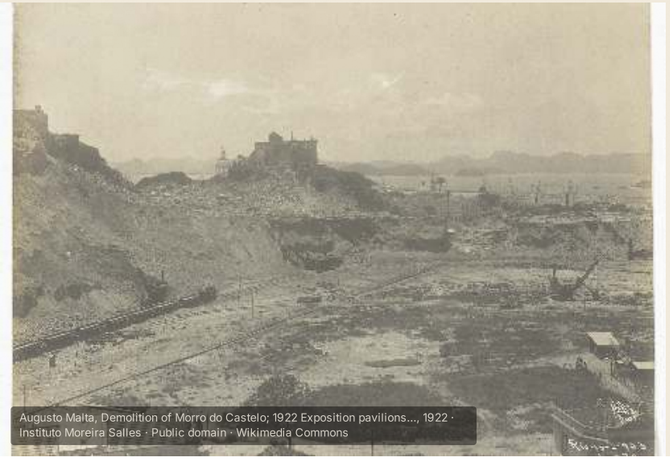
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Rio was rebuilt to look like Paris — and its poor were pushed *up the hills*



Marc Ferrez, Theatro Municipal, c. 1909 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons



Augusto Malta, Demolition of Morro do Castelo, 1922 Exposition pavilions..., 1922 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Around 1900 Rio was notorious for yellow fever and smallpox; foreign ships avoided it. President Rodrigues Alves gave the engineer-mayor **Pereira Passos** and the sanitarian **Oswaldo Cruz** a free hand. The "bota-abaixo" (knock-it-down) demolished hundreds of tenements to drive the Avenida Central through the colonial core and rebuild the port.

In 1904 compulsory smallpox vaccination set off the **Revolta da Vacina**: a week of barricades in Saúde and the port, about 30 dead, hundreds deported to Acre.

Evicted workers moved to the suburbs — or to the hills near their jobs. In 1920–22 the city went further and **razed Morro do Castelo**, its founding hill (left).



"Guerra Vaccino-Obrigateza!" — Oswaldo Cruz as a lancer of vaccine, satirical cartoon, 1904.

Why "favela"?

Canudos veterans, awaiting pay in 1897, camped on Morro da Providência and named it after the favela shrub of the Bahian hills. Hillside shacks existed earlier; the name stuck to them all.

Left: Theatro Municipal (1909), Marc Ferrez; demolition of Morro do Castelo, 1922, Augusto Malta. Benchimol (1990); Sevcenko (1984); Valladares (2005).

The reforms

Francisco Pereira Passos had studied in Paris during Haussmann's transformation. As mayor (1902–06) he drove through the 1.8-km Avenida Central (inaugurated 1905), widened streets, built the Avenida Beira-Mar along the bay toward Botafogo, and banned practices from street vending of offal to cows being milked door to door. Federal engineers rebuilt the port with a new quay wall and landfill — burying the Valongo wharf. Cinelândia's monumental trio followed: the Escola (now Museu) Nacional de Belas Artes (1908), the Theatro Municipal (1909, modelled loosely on the Paris Opéra) and the Biblioteca Nacional (1910).

The demolitions targeted *cortiços* — crowded tenements, often converted colonial houses — which housed much of the working population near the port. An earlier mayor had already destroyed the most famous, the Cabeça de Porco, in 1893. Sidney Chalhoub argues that the war on cortiços fused public health with social control: the "dangerous classes" and the "sick classes" were treated as one.

The Vaccine Revolt (10–16 November 1904)

Oswaldo Cruz's campaigns against yellow fever (mosquito brigades) and plague (rat bounties) were effective; compulsory smallpox vaccination, enforced by inspectors entering homes, was the spark. Grievances about evictions, rising rents and authoritarian methods fused with opposition politics, monarchist and positivist agitation, and a cadet revolt at the military school. Nicolau Sevcenko read the revolt as a popular protest against a modernisation imposed on the poor.

CONTESTED ORIGIN STORY

The "Morro da Favella" story is well documented, but Licia Valladares shows how it became a myth of origin that obscures earlier hillside settlements (Morro de Santo Antônio was occupied by soldiers in the 1890s too) and the deeper cause: a city with no affordable housing near work. The first favela census (1948–50) counted roughly 7% of the city's population in favelas.

The hill that vanished

Morro do Castelo — site of the 1567 city, the Jesuit college and the first cathedral — was demolished in 1920–22 with water jets and railway wagons, displacing several thousand poor residents; the spoil was used to fill land along the bay. The 1922 Centennial Exposition was built on part of the cleared site. Later, Morro de Santo Antônio was largely levelled (1950s) and its earth used to build the Aterro do Flamengo. Rio literally moved its hills into the sea.

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The city grew in three directions — each with its own *class logic*

1960–today

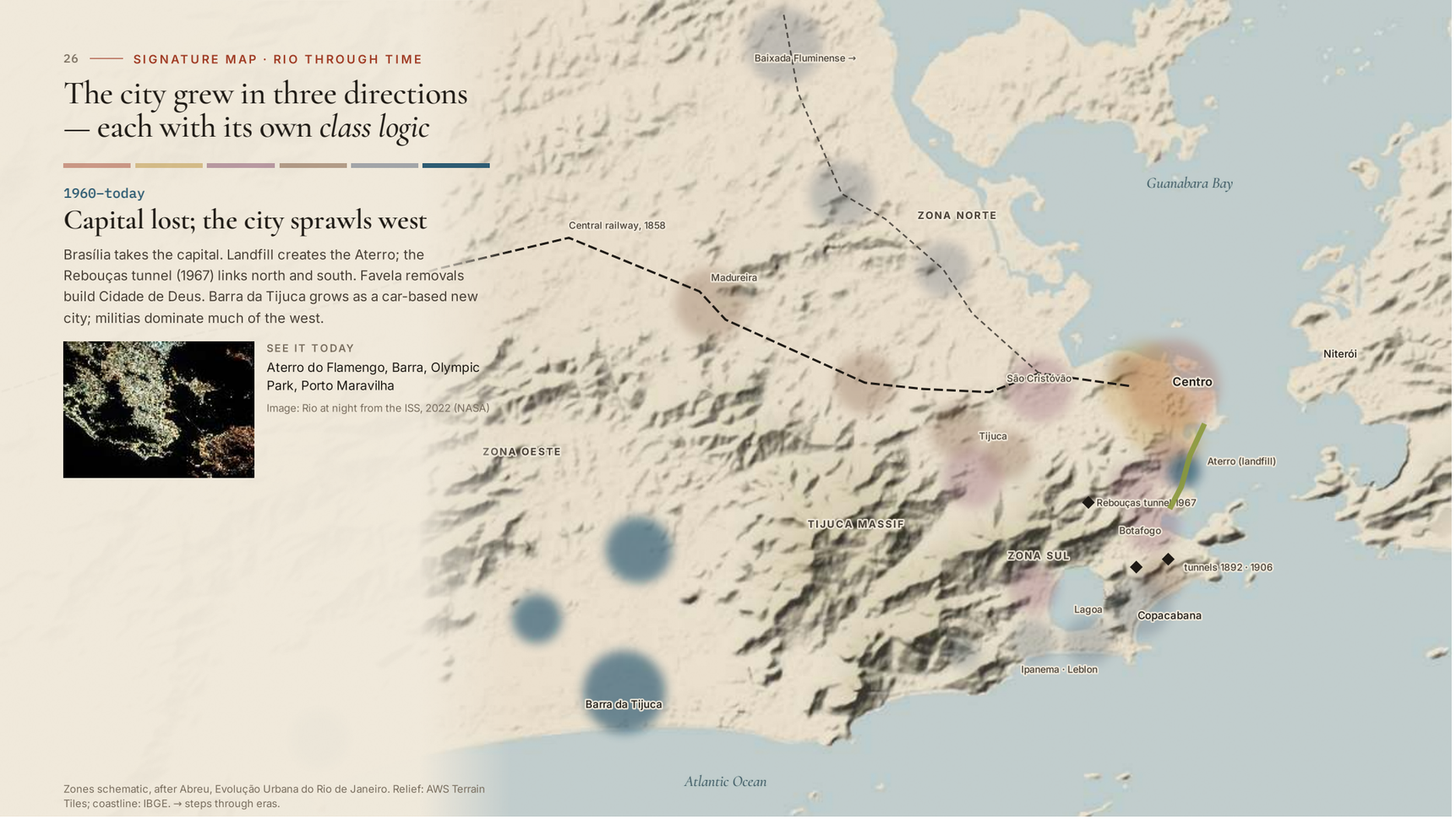
Capital lost; the city sprawls west

Brasília takes the capital. Landfill creates the Aterro; the Rebouças tunnel (1967) links north and south. Favela removals build Cidade de Deus. Barra da Tijuca grows as a car-based new city; militias dominate much of the west.

SEE IT TODAY

Aterro do Flamengo, Barra, Olympic Park, Porto Maravilha

Image: Rio at night from the ISS, 2022 (NASA)



Zones schematic, after Abreu, Evolução Urbana do Rio de Janeiro. Relief: AWS Terrain Tiles; coastline: IBGE. → steps through eras.

This map is the key to reading Rio. The granite massifs — **Tijuca** in the middle, **Pedra Branca** to the west — split the city into three zones, and each grew with a different class logic.

- **Centro (1565 onward)** began on hills and grew onto reclaimed swamp. Several of the hills that defined it (Castelo, Santo Antônio, Senado) have been demolished; the colonial grid survives in the narrow streets around Praça XV, Rua do Ouvidor and the Saara market.
- **Zona Sul (from 1808)**: the court and the rich moved south along the bay — Glória, Catete, Flamengo, Botafogo, Laranjeiras — into country houses. Once tunnels pierced the ridge (1892, 1906), Copacabana and then Ipanema and Leblon became the ocean-facing city of apartment blocks, built for the middle and upper classes. Maurício Abreu calls this the "self-segregation" of the elite along the coast.
- **Zona Norte (from 1858)**: the Dom Pedro II railway (later Central do Brasil) and the Leopoldina line opened the flat lands north and west of the massif to cheap lots, workshops and factories — the *subúrbios*. (In Rio, "subúrbio" means working-class rail suburb, not affluent commuter town.) Madureira, Méier and Bangu became the heartland of samba schools, football clubs and the carioca working class. Avenida Brasil (1946) extended industry and housing into the Baixada Fluminense beyond the city limits.
- **Zona Oeste (from the 1970s)**: Lúcio Costa's 1969 plan for Barra da Tijuca imagined a modernist new town of towers and highways; it became a car-dependent, gated, mall-centred city that many compare to Miami. Further west, Jacarepaguá, Campo Grande and Santa Cruz grew as low-income peripheries — where militias (paramilitary groups often formed by off-duty and ex-police) now control much of daily life.

Hills and landfill

Two processes run through every era: hills were *removed* (Castelo 1922, Santo Antônio 1950s), and the sea was *filled* (port works 1904–11, the Aterro 1960s, Santos Dumont airport on land reclaimed from the bay). And hills that were not removed — too steep for formal construction, often publicly owned — were occupied informally, close to the jobs of the rich neighbourhoods below. That is why Rio, unlike most cities, has poverty both at its periphery and in its centre.

Halo positions and dates are approximate and meant to show the direction of growth rather than precise boundaries.

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Vargas built the modern Brazilian state — and much of it still runs on his blueprint



Government of Brazil, Getúlio Vargas, c. 1930 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

The 1929 crash shattered the coffee republic. Getúlio Vargas, a gaúcho politician, took power in the **Revolution of 1930**; in 1937 he closed Congress and ruled as dictator of the **Estado Novo** until 1945, with censorship, a political police and propaganda. Elected again in 1950, he shot himself in the Catete Palace in 1954 rather than be deposed.

His bargain: **urban formal workers** received rights, minimum wages and state-supervised unions; rural and domestic workers were left out. The divide between the protected formal sector and the informal majority dates from here.

INSTITUTIONS OF THE VARGAS YEARS — ALL STILL EXIST

1930	Ministry of Labour, Industry & Commerce
1932	Secret ballot; votes for women; the work card (carteira)
1936	IBGE, the statistics bureau
1940	National minimum wage
1941	CSN steelworks at Volta Redonda (with US credit)
1942	Vale do Rio Doce (now Vale)
1943	CLT — the Consolidated Labour Laws
1952–53	BNDE development bank; Petrobras (“O petróleo é nosso”)

“I leave life to enter history.”

Vargas’s farewell letter, 24 August 1954. His bedroom in the Catete Palace — now the Museu da República in Flamengo — is preserved as it was.

French, Drowning in Laws (2004); Williams (2001); Abreu (ed.), A Ordem do Progresso (2014); CPDOC.

The road to 1930

By the late 1920s the First Republic faced revolts by junior officers (the *tenentes*: Copacabana Fort 1922, São Paulo 1924, the Prestes Column 1925–27), an urban middle class shut out of politics, and a coffee economy dependent on price support. When the Paulista president Washington Luís broke the informal rotation by backing another Paulista, Júlio Prestes, for the 1930 election, Minas Gerais, Rio Grande do Sul and Paraíba backed Vargas. Prestes won a fraud-ridden election; after the assassination of Vargas's running mate João Pessoa, a revolt led from Rio Grande do Sul toppled the government. Vargas's gaúcho troops famously tied their horses to the obelisk at the end of Avenida Rio Branco.

From provisional government to dictatorship

São Paulo rose in the Constitutionalist Revolution of 1932 and was defeated. A 1934 constitution gave women the vote. After a failed communist uprising in 1935, Vargas used a forged plan of communist revolution (the Plano Cohen) to justify the 1937 coup. The Estado Novo — corporatist, nationalist, influenced by Salazar's Portugal and Mussolini's Italy but never fascist in mass-party form — persecuted communists and integralists alike; the German-Jewish communist Olga Benário Prestes was deported to Nazi Germany and murdered. Vargas bargained between the US and Germany before joining the Allies in 1942; Brazil sent 25,000 troops (the FEB) to Italy in 1944–45, and US Export-Import Bank credit built the Volta Redonda steelworks.

The labour bargain

The Consolidação das Leis do Trabalho (CLT, 1943) gathered a decade of decrees into a code: the 8-hour day, paid holidays, job security rules, labour courts, and unions recognised by — and dependent on — the Ministry of Labour, funded by a compulsory union tax. John French's *Drowning in Laws* argues that the laws were often unenforced and functioned as aspirations that workers then fought to make real. The exclusions were telling: rural workers gained comparable rights only in 1963, and **domestic workers obtained full labour rights only in 2013** — a direct line from the slave household to the present.

Populism

Vargas created the template of Brazilian populism: a leader who speaks directly to urban workers ("trabalhadores do Brasil!" on the radio), with a party machine (the PTB) built on the labour bureaucracy. Admirers call him "father of the poor"; critics stress dictatorship, co-optation and the subordination of unions to the state. Both are right. His suicide letter, read on radio, turned an imminent military ouster into a popular backlash that shaped politics for a decade.

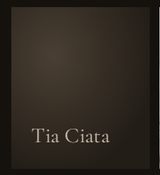
Rio links

The Palácio Gustavo Capanema (Ministry of Education and Health, 1936–45), designed by a team including Lúcio Costa and Oscar Niemeyer with Le Corbusier as consultant and gardens by Burle Marx, is a landmark of modern architecture — and of the Vargas state's ambition. Avenida Presidente Vargas (1944) was cut through the old centre, destroying Praça Onze, the cradle of samba.

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Samba began as a *policed* Afro-Brazilian practice — and became the nation's sound



Tia Ciata


Donga


Pixinguinha


Heitor dos Prazeres


Cartola

Bahian migrants in "Little Africa" — around Pedra do Sal and Praça Onze — hosted the gatherings where samba took shape; the house of the Candomblé priestess **Tia Ciata** was the most famous. *Pelo Telefone*, registered by Donga in 1916, became the first hit recorded as "samba."

In 1928 sambistas of Estácio founded **Deixa Falar**, the first "samba school"; parades began in 1932 and the city made them official in 1935. Radio, records and the Vargas state turned a music once associated with vagrancy into the national rhythm.

Where: Pedra do Sal (Monday nights) · Madureira — Portela & Império Serrano · Mangueira · the Sambódromo (1984), near the vanished Praça Onze.

Right: Portela at the Sambódromo, 2014 (Agência Brasil). Vianna (1995); Sandroni (2001); McCann (2004).


Fernando Frazão / Agência Brasil, Portela samba school parade, Sambódromo, 2014 · CC BY 3.0 br · Wikimedia Commons

Little Africa

After abolition, Afro-Bahian families settled in Saúde, Gamboa and Cidade Nova (around Praça Onze). The *tias baianas* — older women, often Candomblé priestesses and food sellers — hosted parties where religious drumming, the polka-derived *maxixe*, choro and partido-alto improvisation mixed. Tia Ciata (Hilária Batista de Almeida, 1854–1924) is the emblematic figure; musicians such as Pixinguinha, Donga and João da Baiana frequented her house. The painter and composer Heitor dos Prazeres is credited with calling the area "Pequena África."

"Pelo Telefone" (1916–17)

Registered at the National Library by Ernesto dos Santos, "Donga," in November 1916 and recorded early in 1917, it is conventionally the first samba recording. Its authorship was disputed at once — others claimed it was a collective improvisation from Tia Ciata's gatherings — and its rhythm is closer to maxixe than to later samba. Carlos Sandroni shows that the "Estácio paradigm" of the late 1920s (Ismael Silva, Bide, Marçal) created the rhythm associated with modern samba, better suited to marching in parades.

From repression to national symbol

Capoeira was outlawed in the 1890 Penal Code, Afro-Brazilian religions were policed, and sambistas could be arrested for vagrancy. João da Baiana told of having his pandeiro confiscated by police — and of Senator Pinheiro Machado presenting him with an inscribed one. Hermano Vianna's *O Mistério do Samba* argues that samba did not simply rise from the hills to conquer the elite: it was "nationalised" through a long process of mediation among intellectuals (Gilberto Freyre and Sérgio Buarque de Holanda heard Pixinguinha in 1926), radio, the record industry and the state. Under the Estado Novo samba schools were encouraged — and required to celebrate national themes. Carmen Miranda, born in Portugal, took a stylised version to Hollywood.

Carnival

Rio's carnival evolved from the rowdy colonial *entrudo*, through elite "great societies" and the *corso* of decorated cars along Avenida Central (Malta photographed it), to the ranchos and then the samba schools of the hills and suburbs. The parade moved to the purpose-built Sambódromo designed by Oscar Niemeyer in 1984. The schools are neighbourhood institutions rooted in the North Zone and the favelas — Portela (Madureira), Mangueira, Salgueiro, Império Serrano, Beija-Flor (Nilópolis, Baixada) — and today are also big businesses, entangled at times with illegal gambling (the *jogo do bicho*).

SOURCES

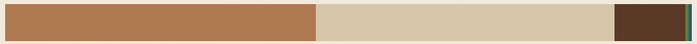
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“Racial democracy” was a powerful national myth — the data have never matched it

In 1933 Gilberto Freyre’s *Casa-Grande & Senzala* turned the old elite fear of race-mixing upside down: miscegenation was Brazil’s genius. In the 1930s–50s football and samba seemed to prove it, and “racial democracy” became official self-image.

Researchers sent by UNESCO in the 1950s expecting harmony found pervasive discrimination; from the 1970s statisticians showed that colour, not just class, shapes life chances. Since 2012 federal universities reserve places for Black, pardo and Indigenous students.

HOW BRAZILIANS IDENTIFY, 2022 CENSUS



Pardo (mixed) **45.3%** White **43.5%** Black (preto) **10.2%** Indigenous **0.6%**

Asian-descent **0.4%**

Black and pardo Brazilians — 55% of the population — earn on average roughly 40% less than white Brazilians and account for around three-quarters of homicide victims.



Football’s colour line

Early clubs like Fluminense (1902) were elite and white. In 1923 **Vasco da Gama**, a club of Portuguese shopkeepers, won Rio’s league with Black and working-class players. Told to drop twelve of them to join the new elite league, Vasco refused in the **“Resposta Histórica”** of 7 April 1924 (left).

Professionalism (1933) opened the game. Yet when Brazil lost the 1950 World Cup final to Uruguay before some 200,000 at the Maracanã, the blame fell disproportionately on Black players, especially the goalkeeper Barbosa.

IBGE Censo 2022 (identificação étnico-racial); IBGE, Desigualdades Sociais por Cor ou Raça; Atlas da Violência (IPEA/FBSP). Freyre (1933); Fernandes (1964); Hasenbalg (1979); Mário Filho (1947).

Freyre’s inversion

Gilberto Freyre, a Pernambucan trained at Columbia under Franz Boas, wrote *Casa-Grande & Senzala* (1933) as a sensuous history of the sugar plantation household. Against the scientific racism and “whitening” doctrines of the First Republic, he presented African and Indigenous contributions and racial mixture as the creative core of Brazilian civilisation. It was a liberating book in 1933 — and it also romanticised slavery as intimate and paternal, minimising violence. Under Vargas and the military, “racial democracy” became a national ideology; to name racism could be called un-Brazilian.

The critique

A UNESCO research programme (1950s), conceived after the Holocaust in hope of finding a model of harmony, produced the opposite: studies by Florestan Fernandes, Roger Bastide and others in São Paulo documented systematic prejudice. Fernandes argued that abolition without integration left Black Brazilians at the bottom of a competitive class society. Carlos Hasenbalg and Nelson do Valle Silva (1979 onward) used census data to show that even controlling for origins and education, non-white Brazilians had lower mobility and earnings — racism, not just the legacy of slavery or class. The Unified Black Movement (MNU, 1978) carried this into politics.

ONGOING DEBATE

Scholars still debate how Brazil’s colour continuum works. The census categories (branco, pardo, preto, amarelo, indígena) are self-declared; many Brazilians shift category over their lives or by context, and the share identifying as pardo or preto has risen as stigma declined. Some argue the continuum softens boundaries; others that it fragments solidarity and lets discrimination hide behind “colour” rather than “race.” Affirmative action — university quotas (federal law 12.711 of 2012, upheld by the Supreme Court) — moved policy decisively toward the critics’ view.

Football

Introduced to São Paulo by Charles Miller in 1894 and to Rio’s elite clubs soon after, football was initially a marker of anglophile distinction. Mário Filho’s *O Negro no Futebol Brasileiro* (1947) narrated its democratisation — Vasco’s 1923 title, the “Resposta Histórica” signed by club president José Augusto Prestes, professionalisation in 1933 — as a parable of national integration; historians have since complicated that story. The 16 July 1950 defeat to Uruguay (the *Maracanazo*), with a crowd officially counted at about 174,000 paying spectators and perhaps 200,000 present, was experienced as national trauma. Then came 1958: Pelé and Garrincha, “futebol-arte,” and a new national self-image that was explicitly mixed-race.

The numbers on the slide

2022 census: pardo 45.3%, white 43.5%, preto 10.2%, Indigenous 0.6%, amarelo 0.4% — the first census since 1991 in which pardos outnumbered whites. Income gaps from IBGE’s PNAD Contínua: average labour income of white workers has been roughly 70% higher than that of Black and pardo workers (equivalently, Black and pardo workers earn roughly 40% less). Homicide: IPEA’s Atlas da Violência reports that about three-quarters of victims are Black or pardo.

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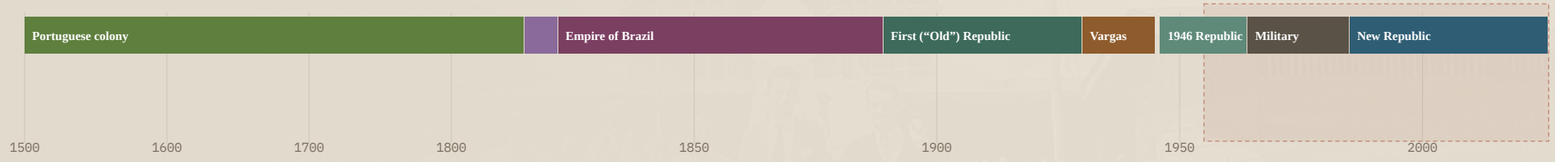
Unknown photographer, Building the National Congress, Esplanada dos Ministérios, 1959 · Arquivo Público do DF · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act IV

Dictatorship, Democracy & Economic Transformation

1955 – 2026

Why has Brazil swung so often between developmental promise and crisis — and between authoritarian and democratic rule?



Act IV covers the developmentalist decades (Kubitschek and Brasília), the military regime (1964–85) and its "economic miracle," the debt and hyperinflation crisis, the democratic transition and the 1988 Constitution, stabilisation with the Real Plan, the commodity boom and the political turbulence since 2013.

Image: construction of the National Congress on the Esplanada dos Ministérios, 1959 (Arquivo Público do Distrito Federal). The twin towers and bowls designed by Oscar Niemeyer were built in under three years on a site that had been empty savanna.



Unknown photographer, Aerial survey of Brasília under construction, 1958 · Arquivo Nacional · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

31 — BRASÍLIA · 1956–1960

A capital built in 41 months to pull Brazil inland — and away from Rio

The 1891 constitution had already reserved land on the central plateau for a new capital. President **Juscelino Kubitschek** (1956–61), promising "fifty years of progress in five," built it: Lúcio Costa's airplane-shaped plan, Oscar Niemeyer's buildings, inaugurated on **21 April 1960**.

Highways radiated to Belém and the west; the car industry arrived around São Paulo. The bill came as inflation and foreign debt.

The planned city never housed its builders: migrant workers (*candangos*) settled in satellite towns that now hold most of the Federal District's 2.8 million people.



Brasília and the new trunk roads (schematic)

What it did to Rio

Rio became the city-state of Guanabara (1960–75), then was merged into Rio de Janeiro state. It lost federal jobs, political centrality and fiscal autonomy — the beginning of a long relative decline that shapes the city you will see.

Left: aerial survey of Brasília, June 1958 (Arquivo Nacional). Holston (1989); CPDOC.

Why move the capital?

The idea was old — the Inconfidentes of 1789 imagined an interior capital, José Bonifácio proposed one in 1823 and the 1891 Republic wrote it into the constitution; the Cruls Mission demarcated a site in 1892–94. Kubitschek, a Minas Gerais physician-politician elected in 1955, made it the "meta-síntese" (synthesis goal) of his Plano de Metas. The rationale was developmental — integrate the empty interior, project the state into the Centre-West and Amazon — and geopolitical. It was also political: a new capital insulated government from the pressure of Rio's streets, press and garrisons, a feature the military later appreciated.

Building it

Lúcio Costa won the 1957 competition with a sketch plan crossing a curved residential axis (the "wings," with superquadras) with the Monumental Axis of ministries; Niemeyer designed the palaces; Burle Marx the gardens. Some 60,000 workers built it in about 41 months. James Holston's anthropology of Brasília shows how a plan meant to abolish class distinctions produced sharp segregation: the Plano Piloto for officials, satellite towns for workers.

The economic model

JK's developmentalism (*desenvolvimentismo*), shaped by the UN's ECLA/CEPAL and economists like Celso Furtado and Roberto Campos, used tariffs, exchange controls, state banks (BNDE) and foreign direct investment — Volkswagen, GM, Ford, Mercedes in the ABC region of São Paulo — to build heavy and consumer-durable industry. Growth averaged about 8% a year in 1956–61; so did deficits, and inflation accelerated, setting up the crisis of the early 1960s.

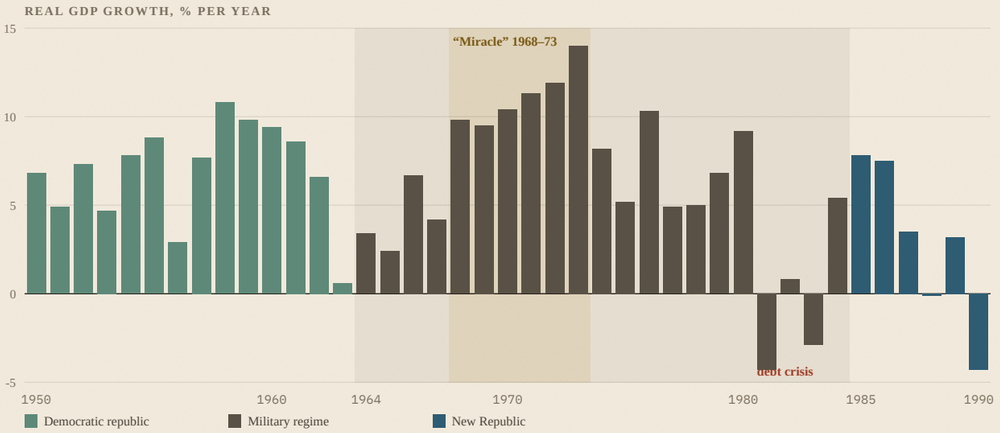
Rio after 1960

The city kept cultural prestige — bossa nova (born in Zona Sul apartments in 1958–59), TV Globo (1965), Petrobras and BNDES headquarters — but lost the federal government's payroll and its role as the arena of national politics. The 1975 merger with Rio de Janeiro state, decided by the military government, joined a rich city to a poorer state; many cariocas date their city's fiscal and political problems from that decision.

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The generals' bargain: rapid growth without democracy — and with rising inequality





Unknown photographer, Troops in Rio during the coup, 2 April 1964 · Arquivo Nacional / Correio da Manhã · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons



Unknown photographer, Construction of the Rio–Niterói bridge, 1971 · Arquivo Nacional · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

GDP: IBGE / Ipeadata (real growth). Left: troops in Rio, 2 April 1964; right: building the Rio–Niterói bridge (1971), a miracle-era megaproject. CNV (2014); Gaspari; Fishlow (1972).

On 31 March–1 April 1964 the army deposed the elected president João Goulart, with support from much of the middle class, business, the press and the Church hierarchy — and a US naval task force on standby. The generals ruled for 21 years, keeping a tame Congress and rotating presidents.

After the **AI-5** decree of December 1968 came censorship and systematic torture; the National Truth Commission (2014) documented **434** people killed or disappeared by the state.

The "miracle" averaged over 10% growth in 1968–73, on wage restraint, state investment and foreign credit. When oil prices quadrupled in 1973 the regime kept growing on borrowed money; foreign debt passed $100 billion and the 1980s became a lost decade.

Why 1964?

João Goulart, Vargas's political heir, took office in 1961 after the surprise resignation of Jânio Quadros, amid inflation approaching 80–90% a year, falling growth and Cold War polarisation after the Cuban Revolution. His push for "base reforms" (land reform, votes for illiterates, limits on profit remittances) and his flirtation with mutinous sergeants and sailors alarmed conservatives and the officer corps. Large "Marches of the Family with God for Liberty" preceded the coup. The US government had funded opposition groups and prepared Operation Brother Sam — a naval task force to support the plotters if civil war broke out; it was not needed. Many civilian backers expected a brief intervention; the military stayed.

Repression

Institutional Act No. 5 (13 December 1968) closed Congress, suspended habeas corpus for political crimes and enabled the worst repression of 1969–74, against armed left groups and many others. The National Truth Commission (2014) listed 434 dead and disappeared victims and named 377 state agents responsible; it also estimated that at least 8,350 Indigenous people died as a result of state action and omission, notably in Amazon development projects. In Rio, the DOI-CODI torture centre operated in an army barracks on Rua Barão de Mesquita in Tijuca. The 1979 Amnesty Law covered both opponents and torturers; the Supreme Court upheld it in 2010.

The miracle and its costs

Finance ministers Roberto Campos and Octávio Gouveia de Bulhões (1964–67) cut inflation and created institutions — a central bank (1964), monetary correction (indexation) of contracts and taxes, a mandatory severance fund (FGTS). Under Antônio Delfim Netto (1967–74), credit, exports and state investment produced growth above 10% a year. Real minimum wages were held down and unions repressed. Delfim is often quoted as saying the cake had to grow before it could be divided.

> **A FAMOUS DEBATE**
>
> The 1970 census showed sharply rising inequality (the Gini index rose from about 0.50 in 1960 to about 0.57 in 1970). Albert Fishlow (1972) blamed regime policy — wage squeeze and repression of unions. Carlos Langoni (1973), defending the government, attributed it to market forces: rapid growth raised the premium on scarce educated labour. The debate founded modern Brazilian inequality research; most scholars now see both mechanisms at work.

Debt

After the 1973 oil shock (Brazil imported most of its oil), Geisel's Second National Development Plan (1974) chose to "grow through" with heavy state investment financed by petrodollar loans — steel, petrochemicals, hydroelectricity (Itaipu), nuclear power, the alcohol fuel programme (Proálcool). When US interest rates soared in 1979–81 and Mexico defaulted in 1982, Brazil's floating-rate debt became unpayable. The 1980s brought recession, IMF programmes, a 1987 moratorium — and inflation.

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Inflation became a way of life — until an ingenious plan broke it in 1994

CONSUMER PRICE INFLATION, % PER YEAR — LOGARITHMIC SCALE · FAILED STABILISATION PLANS MARKED



HOW THE REAL PLAN WORKED

1. Indexation had become the disease

Wages, rents and contracts were all corrected for past inflation, so inflation reproduced itself (“inertial inflation”). Price freezes failed five times.

2. A virtual currency first

From March 1994 every price was quoted in the URV — a unit of account worth about one dollar — while people still paid in cruzeiros reais. Prices realigned voluntarily, without a freeze.

3. Then the switch

On 1 July 1994 the URV became the real (R$1 = CR$2,750). Inflation fell from about 2,500% to 22% in a year, then single digits.

Five currencies in eight years: cruzado (1986), cruzado novo (1989), cruzeiro (1990), cruzeiro real (1993), real (1994).

IBGE IPCA (1980–2025); FGV IGP-DI (1960–79). Arida & Lara Resende (1985); Franco (1995).

Why inflation became chronic

From the 1950s Brazil financed development and deficits with money creation. The military regime's 1964 innovation — *correção monetária*, indexing contracts, taxes and savings to past inflation — made inflation tolerable for those with bank accounts and indexed assets, but it also built memory into prices: each period's inflation became the floor for the next. After the oil shocks and the debt crisis, with deficits monetised and the exchange rate repeatedly devalued, inflation climbed from about 100% (1980) to over 200% (1983–85).

Five failed plans

The Cruzado Plan (February 1986) froze prices and created a new currency; inflation fell briefly, a consumption boom helped the government win the November 1986 elections, then shortages and black markets forced its abandonment. Bresser (1987) and Summer (1989) followed. Fernando Collor (March 1990) froze about 80% of financial assets — savings accounts above a small limit were blocked for 18 months — a trauma Brazilians still mention. Inflation returned each time.

The insight

Economists at PUC-Rio — Persio Arida and André Lara Resende (the "Larida" proposal, 1984), with Edmar Bacha, Gustavo Franco, Pedro Malan and others — argued that inertial inflation was a coordination problem. If everyone could simultaneously switch their price-setting to a stable unit, inertia would vanish without a freeze. The Real Plan, launched under finance minister Fernando Henrique Cardoso in President Itamar Franco's government, did exactly that via the URV (Unidade Real de Valor), introduced 1 March 1994, accompanied by a fiscal adjustment fund, high interest rates and, initially, a strong exchange rate.

Consequences

- **Distribution.** Hyperinflation was a tax on the poor, who held cash and lacked indexed accounts. Poverty fell sharply in 1994–95.
- **Politics.** Cardoso won the presidency in October 1994 in the first round and was re-elected in 1998.
- **The "tripod."** After a currency crisis forced the real to float in January 1999, Brazil adopted the macro framework it still uses: inflation targeting by the central bank, a floating exchange rate and primary fiscal surpluses (Fiscal Responsibility Law, 2000). The legacy: high real interest rates — the Selic policy rate stood at 13.75% in October 2026.

Data: IPCA (IBGE) from 1980; IGP-DI (FGV) for 1960–79, which measures a broader price index. 2025 IPCA: 4.26%.

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Democracy returned by negotiation — with a constitution that promised more than the state could pay for



Jorge Henrique Singh, Diretas Já rally, 1984 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Diretas Já, 1984: rallies of up to a million people — including at Candelária in Rio — demanded direct presidential elections. Congress voted the amendment down.

1974	Geisel announces a “slow, gradual and secure” opening
1979	Amnesty — for exiles and for torturers
1985	Civilian president chosen indirectly
1988	New constitution (5 October)
1989	First direct presidential vote since 1960

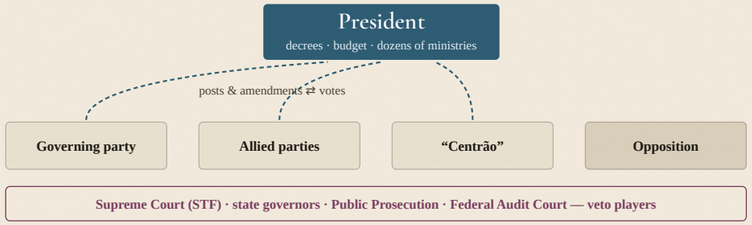
What 1988 created

A universal public health system (SUS); pensions and social assistance as rights; votes from 16 and for the illiterate; Indigenous and quilombola land rights; an independent public prosecution service; strong judicial review.

How the system works

A powerful president who governs through decrees and coalitions; a Congress fragmented among a dozen-plus parties, with a pragmatic “Centrão” that trades votes for posts and budget amendments; a Supreme Court that often arbitrates politics.

COALITIONAL PRESIDENTIALISM (SCHEMATIC)



Since 1988: two presidents impeached (Collor 1992, Rousseff 2016) and more than 130 constitutional amendments.

Abranches (1988, 2018); Fausto & Fausto (2014); Constitution of 1988.

A transition controlled from above — then pushed from below

President Ernesto Geisel (1974–79) began a liberalisation meant to return power to civilians on the military's terms, against resistance from the hard-line security apparatus. Pressure from below grew: the 1978–80 metalworkers' strikes in São Bernardo do Campo, led by Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, the Catholic Church's base communities, the press, lawyers' and scientists' associations. The 1979 amnesty let exiles return; party reform produced the PT (1980) and other parties; in 1982 opposition governors were elected in major states (Leonel Brizola in Rio).

In 1984 the **Diretas Já** campaign filled squares across the country — a rally at Candelária in Rio on 10 April drew perhaps a million people — but on 25 April the Dante de Oliveira amendment for direct elections fell 22 votes short. In January 1985 the electoral college chose the moderate opposition leader Tancredo Neves; he fell ill on the eve of inauguration and died on 21 April. His vice-president José Sarney, a former regime ally, governed through hyperinflation.

The "Citizen Constitution"

The 1987–88 Constituent Assembly, presided over by Ulysses Guimarães, wrote a long, detailed, rights-heavy document: universal health care (SUS), social security as a right, a guaranteed minimum pension equal to the minimum wage, labour protections, decentralisation of revenue to states and municipalities, a strengthened Ministério Público, and a Supreme Court with broad powers of review. Many spending commitments were constitutionally earmarked, which makes fiscal adjustment hard and explains why so many reforms (pensions 2019, tax 2023) require constitutional amendments.

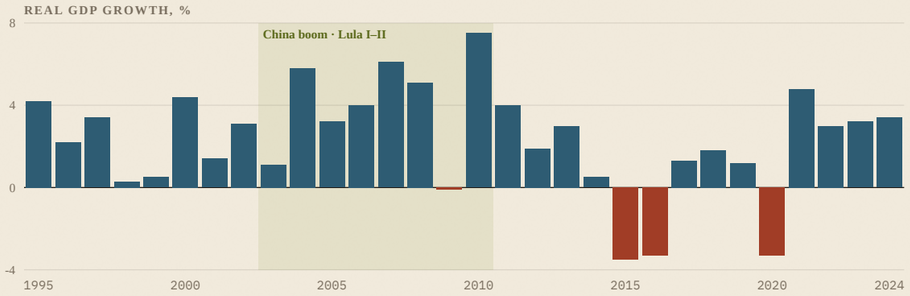
Coalitional presidentialism

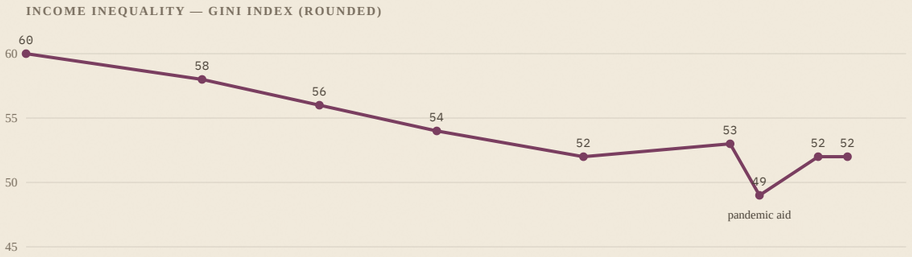
Sérgio Abranches coined the term in 1988: a directly elected president, a fragmented Congress elected by open-list proportional representation, and federalism. Presidents assemble broad coalitions by distributing ministries, state-company posts and budget amendments. The system has been remarkably resilient — it survived two impeachments — but it rewards patronage and has been at the heart of corruption scandals (the *mensalão* vote-buying case of 2005; the Lava Jato investigations of 2014–21 into Petrobras contracts). Since the 2010s Congress has captured a growing share of the discretionary budget through mandatory amendments, shifting power away from the presidency.

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A commodity boom, real social gains — then a decade of crisis and polarisation





Stable money (FHC, 1995–2002) and then Chinese demand for iron ore, soy and oil financed the **Lula** years (2003–10): real minimum-wage gains, the Bolsa Família cash-transfer programme, credit, and a historic fall in poverty and inequality.

From 2013: mass street protests, the **Lava Jato** corruption probe, the worst recession on record (2015–16), the impeachment of Dilma Rousseff (2016) and the election of the far-right Jair Bolsonaro (2018). After a riot stormed Congress, the presidential palace and the Supreme Court on 8 January 2023, the Court convicted Bolsonaro in 2025 of plotting a coup.

AS OF 24 OCTOBER 2026

Election: first round (4 Oct) — Flávio Bolsonaro 47.0%, President Lula 45.2%; the runoff is on **25 October**, result not known at writing. Jair Bolsonaro is serving a 27-year sentence under house arrest.

Economy: policy rate (Selic) 13.75% after September's cut; inflation expected near 5% for 2026; growth forecasts below 2%.

GDP: IBGE / Ipeadata through 2024. Gini: World Bank PIP / IBGE PNAD, rounded. Election: TSE count via Al Jazeera & Washington Post (Oct 2026); Selic: BCB Copom (Sept 2026); STF AP 2668. Contemporary figures provisional.

The good decade

Cardoso (1995–2002) consolidated stabilisation, privatised telecoms, steel and Vale, and created early cash-transfer programmes. Lula (2003–10), the former metalworker, kept the macro tripod while raising the real minimum wage, expanding Bolsa Família (conditional cash transfers reaching over 13 million families), widening credit and university access. The commodity super-cycle driven by China — now Brazil's largest trading partner — boosted terms of trade. Poverty fell sharply, and the Gini index declined from roughly 0.58 in 2001 to about 0.52 by 2014, one of the largest sustained declines anywhere. Brazil left the UN hunger map in 2014; pre-salt oil discoveries (2006–07), the 2014 World Cup and the 2016 Rio Olympics crowned a mood of arrival.

The bad decade

Growth slowed after 2011; Dilma Rousseff's interventionist "New Economic Matrix" (subsidised credit, price controls on fuel and electricity, tax breaks) coincided with falling commodity prices. The June 2013 protests began over bus fares and became a broad revolt against the political class. Lava Jato, launched in 2014, exposed a cartel of construction firms paying kickbacks on Petrobras contracts to parties in the governing coalition; it convicted dozens of politicians and executives — including Lula in 2017 (jailed 2018–19) — before the Supreme Court annulled his convictions in 2021 on jurisdictional grounds and found the lead judge, Sergio Moro, biased. Rousseff was impeached in 2016 for budget manoeuvres. GDP fell about 7% in 2015–16.

Polarisation

Jair Bolsonaro, a former army captain and long-time backbencher, won in 2018 on anti-PT, anti-corruption, pro-gun and socially conservative platforms, with strong evangelical support. His government passed a pension reform (2019); Brazil suffered one of the world's highest COVID-19 death tolls (over 700,000). Lula narrowly beat him in October 2022. On 8 January 2023 Bolsonaro supporters ransacked the buildings of the three branches of government in Brasília. In September 2025 the Supreme Court's First Panel convicted Bolsonaro and senior aides of attempting a coup, sentencing him to 27 years and 3 months; he has been held under humanitarian house arrest since March 2026.

Where things stand (24 October 2026)

- **Election:** in the first round on 4 October 2026 Senator Flávio Bolsonaro (PL), the former president's son, led with 47.03% of valid votes to Lula's 45.16%; the PL also won the most seats in both chambers. Final polls had shown Lula ahead, and late runoff polls showed a near tie. The runoff is on 25 October 2026 — its result was not known when this deck was prepared.
- **Economy:** GDP grew 3.4% in 2024; 2025 inflation (IPCA) was 4.26%. In September 2026 the central bank cut the Selic to 13.75% (the latest in a series of cuts from a peak of 15% reached in 2025), with market (Focus) expectations of inflation around 5% and growth below 2% for 2026. These figures are provisional and should be re-checked.

INTERPRETATION

Is Brazil stuck in a "middle-income trap"? Its income per head relative to the United States is roughly where it was around 1980. Explanations stress low investment and savings, weak productivity growth, a complex tax system, poor basic education, high real interest rates and an economy re-concentrated in commodities. Others point to genuine institutional gains: an independent central bank (formally since 2021), a sophisticated financial system and agribusiness that leads the world in productivity.

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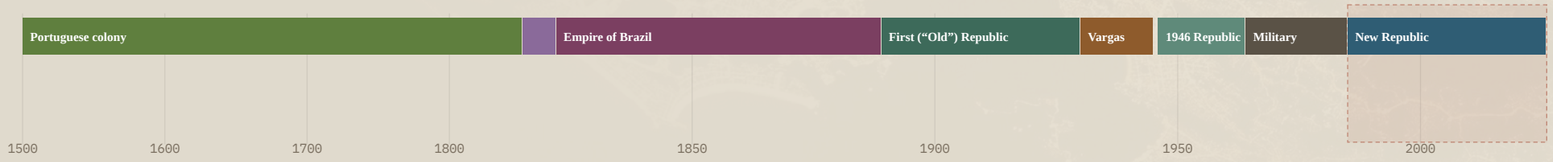
NASA, Rio de Janeiro at night from the International Space Stat..., 2022 · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

Act V

Reading Brazil and Rio Today

the present, through the past

Now that you know the history, what do the regions, the inequalities and the shape of Rio itself tell you?



Act V turns the history into tools for seeing: a mental map of Brazil's regions, an account of why inequality is so durable, an explanation of Rio's distinctive social geography, and an annotated map of the city that connects specific places to the story.

Image: Rio de Janeiro at night photographed from the International Space Station (Expedition 67, 2022; NASA, public domain). The dark shapes inside the lit city are the Tijuca and Pedra Branca massifs — the mountains that organise everything in the following slides.

Five regions, five histories — each the residue of a different cycle



REGION	POP.	GDP	WHERE IT COMES FROM
North Manaus · Belém	8.5%	≈6%	Amazon frontier: missions, rubber boom (1879–1912), Manaus Free Trade Zone (1967), today's deforestation frontier and largest Indigenous territories.
Northeast Salvador · Recife · Fortaleza	26.9%	≈14%	The original sugar colony and Afro-Brazilian heartland; drought-prone sertão; for a century the great source of migrants to Rio and São Paulo. Lula's electoral base.
Southeast São Paulo · Rio · Belo Horizonte	41.8%	≈52%	Gold, coffee, industry and finance in succession. Holds both mega-cities, most of the country's capital — and its largest urban peripheries.
South Porto Alegre · Curitiba	14.7%	≈17%	Gaúcho cattle frontier facing the River Plate, then German and Italian smallholder colonies and cooperatives. Highest human-development scores.
Centre-West Brasília · Goiânia · Cuiabá	8%	≈11%	Brasília, and since the 1970s the Cerrado agribusiness frontier — soy, corn, cotton, cattle — made possible by soil science. Fastest-growing region.

Three capitals of three kinds: Brasília governs, São Paulo produces and finances, Rio represents — the country's showcase, oil-and-gas hub, media centre and the city through which most foreigners first meet Brazil. Salvador, the first capital (1549–1763), remains its Afro-Brazilian cultural capital.

Population: IBGE Censo 2022. GDP shares: IBGE Contas Regionais (c. 2021), rounded.

Brazil's five official macro-regions are statistical conveniences, but they map remarkably well onto the historical cycles in this presentation. Each region carries the institutions, demography and elites of the era that made it.

- **Northeast** — the colonial sugar core, then two centuries of relative decline. It has the highest share of Black and pardo population after the North, the lowest incomes, a powerful regional culture (forró, frevo, maracatu, Candomblé in Bahia, the literature of the sertão) and — after the great droughts and the rise of industry in the Southeast — supplied millions of migrants south. Rio's Feira de São Cristóvão and São Paulo's working-class districts are full of nordestinos. Since the 2000s cash transfers and minimum wage policy have made it the electoral bastion of Lula and the PT.
- **Southeast** — Minas (gold, then dairy, mining and politics), Rio (court and capital), São Paulo (coffee, industry, finance), Espírito Santo. About 42% of the people and about half of GDP.
- **South** — contested frontier with the Spanish world (hence the gaúcho cattle culture shared with Uruguay and Argentina), then 19th-century European colonisation on smallholdings. Higher equality and education than the national average.
- **Centre-West** — almost empty until Brasília and the agricultural revolution of the Cerrado. Embrapa (the state agricultural research company, 1973) developed liming and soy varieties for acidic tropical soils; Brazil became the world's largest soy exporter. The region is now one of the richest per capita — and a centre of conservative, agribusiness politics.
- **North** — the Amazon. About 60% of the Amazon rainforest lies in Brazil; deforestation, mining and land-grabbing are its central political issues. Belém hosted the UN climate conference COP30 in November 2025.

Regional GDP shares vary year to year with commodity prices; the Centre-West's share has risen steadily since 2000.

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Why inequality endures: five layers laid down over five centuries

LAID DOWN	LAYER	MECHANISM	WHAT YOU CAN STILL MEASURE
1530s–1850	Land	Royal land grants to the few; then the 1850 Land Law made land purchasable only for cash, just as the slave trade ended.	Land ownership remains among the most concentrated on earth (land Gini ≈ 0.86).
1550–1888	Slavery without reconstruction	Four centuries of slavery; abolition with no land, schooling or compensation; subsidised European immigrants preferred for the new jobs.	Black and pardo Brazilians earn roughly 40% less than white Brazilians.
1930s–	A dual labour state	Vargas protected urban formal workers; rural and domestic workers were excluded for decades.	About 4 in 10 workers are informal, outside the protections of the CLT.
1964–1994	Inflation & indexation	Indexed accounts shielded the banked middle and upper classes; cash-holding poor paid the inflation tax.	A legacy of very high real interest rates that reward holders of public debt.
1988–	Fiscal design	Taxes lean on consumption; dividends were untaxed from 1996; generous public pensions; free public universities long dominated by the privately schooled.	The top 1% receive roughly a quarter of national income (tax data).

But inequality is not fate. Between 2001 and 2014 the Gini index fell by about six points — through a rising minimum wage, mass schooling, pensions and cash transfers — before stalling. A 2025 income-tax law, in force from 2026, exempts low earners and imposes a minimum tax on very high incomes, including dividends.

Read the layers as **sediment**: each era added a mechanism without removing the earlier ones. That is why Brazil can be a high-tech agricultural power with world-class banks and, at the same time, a country where millions live without sewerage.

IBGE Censo Agropecuário 2017 (land Gini); PNAD Contínua (informality, income by colour); Souza (2018) on top incomes; Arretche (ed., 2015).

"Why is Brazil so unequal?" has no single answer. This slide organises the main explanations historically, because each was added at a particular moment and none was ever fully removed.

- **Land.** Colonial sesmarias granted vast estates; squatting (posse) was common but insecure. The 1850 Land Law ended free occupation of public land precisely as free labour was about to replace slave labour, keeping freedpeople and immigrants landless. No significant land reform followed; the 2017 agricultural census shows a Gini of land ownership of about 0.86.
- **Race.** Abolition without reconstruction, followed by state-subsidised European immigration and decades of "racial democracy" ideology that denied the problem. Measured gaps in income, education, wealth and exposure to violence remain large.
- **The dual labour state.** Vargas-era labour rights created a protected formal sector; the informal majority — rural workers until 1963, domestic workers fully only in 2013, and today's informal workers (roughly 38–40% of the employed in PNAD Contínua in 2024–25) — sat outside it.
- **Inflation.** High inflation redistributed from the poor (who held cash) to those with indexed assets. The Real Plan's end of high inflation was one of the most progressive policies in Brazilian history.
- **Fiscal design.** Brazil's tax burden is high for a middle-income country (about a third of GDP), but it falls heavily on goods and services rather than on incomes and wealth; dividends were exempt from personal income tax from 1996 until the 2025 reform; public spending on pensions is very large, and until affirmative action (2012) the free federal universities were dominated by graduates of private schools. Pedro Souza's work with income-tax records shows the top 1% receiving roughly a quarter of national income — higher than household surveys suggest.

The other side

Between 2001 and 2014 the household-survey Gini fell from about 0.59 to about 0.52 — one of the largest declines recorded anywhere — thanks to the minimum wage (which also sets pensions), expanded schooling, Bolsa Família and formalisation. Progress stalled with the 2015–16 recession. The 2023 tax reform (on consumption taxes, phased in from 2026) and the 2025 income-tax law (Law 15.270/2025: exemption up to R$5,000 a month; minimum effective rate on annual incomes above R$600,000; withholding on large dividends) are the most significant attempts in decades to change the fiscal layer.

> INTERPRETATION
>
> Economists disagree on weights. Some emphasise education (the skill premium: universal primary schooling came late — half of adults were illiterate in 1950); others institutions and political power (elites shaping taxes and spending); others race-specific discrimination. The historical layering suggests they reinforce one another.

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Wilfredor, Ipanema and Leblon from Dois Irmãos, with Lagoa and Canta..., 2024 · CC0 · Wikimedia Commons

In Rio, favelas look down on the beach — and the true periphery is out of sight

Hills beside the jobs

Steep, often publicly owned slopes were left out of the formal market; workers built there, a walk from the households, hotels and building sites of the Zona Sul. Rocinha — 72,021 people in 2022 — sits between Gávea and São Conrado.

The periphery you won't see

Most poor cariocas live far from the beaches — in the North and West Zones and the Baixada Fluminense, with commutes of two hours or more. About 15% of greater Rio lives in favelas (2022 census).

Policy swings

Removals in the 1960s–70s (to Cidade de Deus and Vila Kennedy); upgrading from the 1990s; armed "pacification" from 2008; today drug factions and militias contest territory. A police raid in Penha and Alemão on 28 October 2025 killed more than 120 people — the deadliest in the city's history.

Top: Ipanema and Leblon from Dois Irmãos, with Lagoa and the Cantagalo hill (Wilfredor, 2024, CC0). IBGE Censo 2022; Perlman (2010); Valladares (2005); Rio Public Defender's Office (2025).

Why poverty sits in the middle of wealth

In most Latin American cities the poor live mainly at the urban edge. Rio has that pattern too — but it also has favelas in the heart of its richest districts. The reasons are geographic and historical: the Tijuca massif's steep slopes were unattractive and often legally unbuildable for the formal market; they were close to employment in domestic service, construction and commerce; and from the 1890s onward (Act III) displacement from the centre pushed the poor uphill. Mid-20th-century migration from the Northeast and from the state's interior swelled favelas in every zone.

Removal and its legacy

Under Governor Carlos Lacerda (1960–65) and the military regime, tens of thousands of residents were removed from Zona Sul favelas — Praia do Pinto (1969) and Catacumba (1970) by the Lagoa among them — to distant housing estates such as Vila Kennedy (1964, partly US-funded through the Alliance for Progress) and Cidade de Deus (1960s), later made famous by the 2002 film. Janice Perlman followed families from 1968 to the 2000s and found real gains in education and consumption but persistent stigma and, increasingly, violence. After redemocratisation, Leonel Brizola stopped removals; the Favela-Bairro programme (1994) upgraded infrastructure.

Violence and the state

From the 1980s drug-trafficking factions (Comando Vermelho, founded in the prison system in 1979, and rivals) controlled many favelas. From the late 1990s militias — groups often formed by police and ex-police — took over large parts of the West Zone and the Baixada, extorting fees for gas, transport, internet and property. The Pacifying Police Units (UPPs, 2008–) brought temporary reductions in violence before a fiscal collapse in the state (2016–17) undermined them. Police killings remain very high. On 28 October 2025 a large operation against the Comando Vermelho in the Penha and Alemão complexes killed, by official count, initially 64 and, by later tallies, more than 120 people, including four police officers; human-rights organisations called it a massacre, the state governor called it a success.

Data

Census 2022: 16.4 million Brazilians (8.1%) live in what IBGE now calls "favelas and urban communities"; for the Rio urban concentration the share is 14.8%. Rocinha (72,021) is the most populous single favela in Brazil; Rio das Pedras, in the militia-dominated West Zone, is second by number of households.

If you visit a favela, go with a resident-run organisation or guide; avoid "safari" tours. Conditions vary block by block and day by day.

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Twenty-four places where Rio's history is still visible

Hover or click a number.

1 COURT & EMPIRE (1808–1889)

Praça XV & Paço Imperial

WHAT YOU'LL SEE

A plain colonial palace on a square by the ferry docks; the Arco do Teles alley beside it.

WHAT IT MEANS

The governors' house (1743) became the royal palace in 1808. João VI was acclaimed here (1818); Princess Isabel signed the Golden Law here (1888). Brazil's political centre for two centuries.

Slides 15, 20

LAYERS

- Colonial (1565–1808)
- Gold & slave port (1700–1850)
- Court & Empire (1808–1889)
- Republic & Belle Époque (1889–1945)
- Modern Rio (1945–today)

Positions approximate. Relief: AWS Terrain Tiles; coastline IBGE.

A walking logic for the historical sites:

- **Centro & the port (one long morning):** Praça XV and the Paço Imperial → Arco do Teles and Rua do Ouvidor → Candelária → Mosteiro de São Bento → Praça Mauá (MAR, Museu do Amanhã) → Valongo Wharf → Instituto Pretos Novos → Pedra do Sal. Add the Real Gabinete Português de Leitura and the Confeitaria Colombo (1894) for the Belle Époque.
- **Cinelândia, Lapa, Santa Teresa:** Theatro Municipal, Biblioteca Nacional and Museu Nacional de Belas Artes; the Esplanada do Castelo; the Arcos da Lapa and the Selarón steps; the tram up to Santa Teresa.
- **The bay shore south:** Glória church (1739) → Catete Palace (Museu da República) → the Aterro do Flamengo → Botafogo → Urca and Sugarloaf (the 1565 founding site).
- **The Atlantic city:** Copacabana (fort, palace, promenade) → Ipanema → Leblon; Lagoa and Jardim Botânico; Corcovado through the Tijuca Forest.
- **North Zone:** Quinta da Boa Vista and the São Cristóvão fair; Maracanã; for samba, Madureira (Portela, Império Serrano) on a rehearsal night.

All sites

1. **Praça XV & Paço Imperial** — The governors' house (1743) became the royal palace in 1808. João VI was acclaimed here (1818); Princess Isabel signed the Golden Law here (1888). Brazil's political centre for two centuries.
2. **Mosteiro de São Bento** — Founded on one of the four hills of the first city; its gilding is the money of sugar and Minas gold made visible.
3. **Valongo Wharf** — Where hundreds of thousands of enslaved Africans landed; buried twice, rediscovered in 2011, UNESCO site since 2017.
4. **Pedra do Sal** — Heart of "Little Africa," where Bahian migrants and freed people settled after abolition and samba took shape.
5. **Morro da Providência** — The "Morro da Favella" of the Canudos veterans (1897) — the name that became the word.
6. **Museu do Amanhã & Praça Mauá** — Olympic-era Porto Maravilha (2009–16) demolished an elevated highway and remade the old port — the works that uncovered Valongo.
7. **Theatro Municipal & Cinelândia** — The showpiece of Pereira Passos's Paris-on-the-tropics (1902–10). Nearby, the flat Esplanada do Castelo is the ghost of Rio's founding hill.
8. **Arcos da Lapa** — Completed c. 1750 to water a city made populous by gold. The Selarón steps are nearby.
9. **Santa Teresa** — 19th-century retreat of the well-off above the hot centre; later artists' quarter.
10. **Catete Palace** — Presidential palace 1897–1960; Vargas shot himself in its bedroom in 1954.
11. **Aterro do Flamengo** — Built in the 1960s on landfill from the demolished Morro de Santo Antônio; landscape by Burle Marx. The original shore is the road behind it.
12. **Botafogo** — The aristocratic suburb of the 19th-century Empire, reached along the bay before tunnels opened the ocean beaches.
13. **Sugarloaf & Urca** — At its foot Estácio de Sá founded the city on 1 March 1565; forts on both sides of the narrow bay mouth.
14. **Copacabana** — Opened by tunnels in 1892 and 1906; the Atlantic city of the 20th-century middle class; the 1922 Fort revolt began here.
15. **Ipanema** — Bossa nova's neighbourhood (late 1950s–60s); also the clearest view of Rio's hill-and-beach social geography.
16. **Leblon** — Site of the 1880s abolitionist "quilombo" where camellias — the movement's symbol — were grown.
17. **Jardim Botânico & Lagoa** — Founded by João VI in 1808; Lagoa-side favelas were removed around 1969–70.
18. **Rocinha** — Brazil's most populous favela (72,021 in 2022).
19. **Corcovado & Tijuca Forest** — The forest is a garden: replanted from 1861 after coffee had stripped the hills and threatened the water supply.
20. **Maracanã** — The 1950 World Cup defeat — and the North Zone's football culture.
21. **Quinta da Boa Vista** — The emperors' residence, donated by a slave-trading merchant in 1808.
22. **Sambódromo** — Built near the vanished Praça Onze, cradle of samba, destroyed for Avenida Presidente Vargas (1944).
23. **Ilha Fiscal** — Scene of the Empire's last ball, 9 November 1889 — six days before the Republic.
24. **Niterói** — Founded in 1573 as the village of Araribóia, the Temiminó chief who fought for the Portuguese.

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3. UNESCO World Heritage Centre, “Valongo Wharf Archaeological Site” (inscribed 2017). ↗

Eight things you will now notice in Rio — and what they mean



Flat ground where hills used to be

The Esplanada do Castelo and the area around Largo da Carioca are the sites of demolished hills — including the one the city was founded on.



A shoreline that is mostly man-made

The Aterro, Santos Dumont airport and the port all stand on landfill — much of it made from those hills. Glória church once stood by the water.



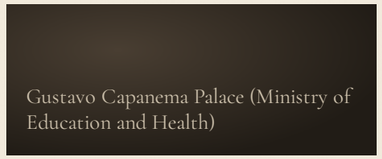
A palace that is just a big house

The Paço is modest because it was a colonial governor's residence improvised into the seat of an empire.



Africa underfoot in the port

In Saúde and Gamboa the Valongo stones, the Pretos Novos cemetery and Pedra do Sal mark the largest slave port in the Americas.



Three cities on one walk

Colonial churches, Passos's Parisian façades and Vargas-era modernism (the Capanema Palace) stand within a few blocks — each era rebuilt the centre in its own image.



The mountain is a class line

Zona Sul faces the ocean; the Zona Norte lies behind the massif along the railway. Tunnels, not distance, separate them. Favelas climb the slopes in between.



The beach is the public square

Since the 1920s the beach replaced the bay as Rio's stage — the one space everyone shares, subdivided by posto, tribe and neighbourhood.



The rainforest is a 19th-century garden

Coffee stripped the Tijuca hills; from 1861 the Empire replanted them to save the water supply — one of the first large reforestations anywhere.

Photographs: Augusto Malta (Morro do Castelo, 1921); Pppires; Fulviusbsas; Ian Storni Machado; Henrique Liberal; Chensiyuan; Mteixeira62; Halley Pacheco de Oliveira — via Wikimedia Commons (see credits).

A few more things to look for:

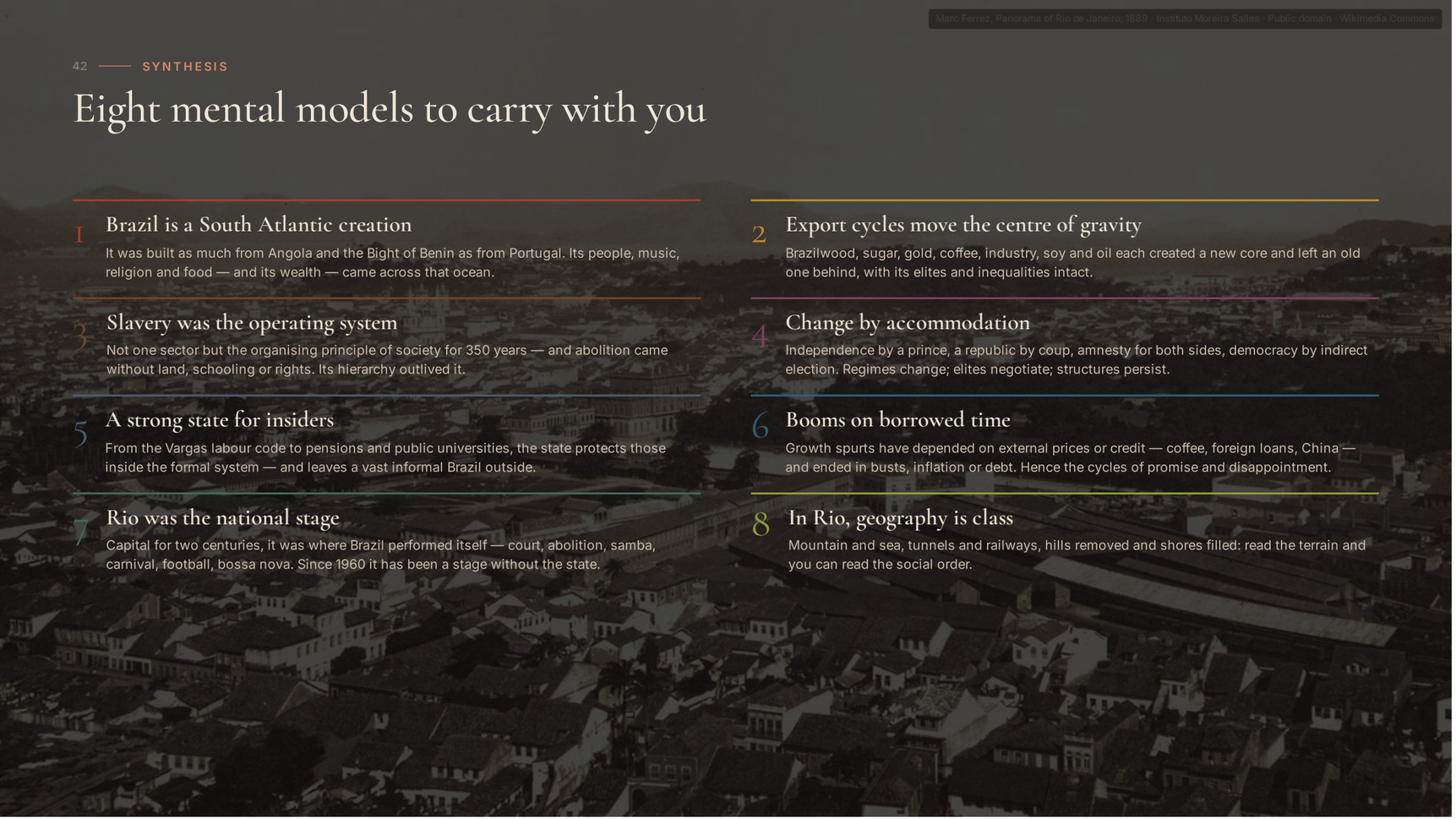
- **Street names are a history lesson.** Rua Primeiro de Março (end of the Paraguayan War, 1 March 1870) was the colonial Rua Direita; Avenida Presidente Vargas; Rua Visconde de Pirajá in Ipanema (an independence-war hero); Praça Tiradentes, where the Inconfidência martyr was executed in 1792.
- **Portuguese tiles (azulejos) and the Portuguese pavement** (black-and-white calçada) — including Burle Marx's Copacabana waves (1970), an expansion of an older Portuguese design.
- **"Subúrbio" means working-class**: the rail suburbs of the North Zone (Madureira, Méier, Bangu) are where samba schools, big football fan bases and much of the city's popular culture live.
- **Nordestino Rio:** the Feira de São Cristóvão, forró, carne-de-sol — the imprint of 20th-century migration from the Northeast.
- **Religion in plain sight:** baroque Catholic churches; offerings to Iemanjá on the beach at New Year (Afro-Brazilian religion); and, increasingly, Pentecostal churches in the suburbs — evangelicals are now around a quarter or more of Brazilians, reshaping politics.
- **Football colours as class and neighbourhood:** Flamengo (the most popular club in Brazil), Fluminense (historically elite), Vasco (Portuguese immigrants and the 1924 "Resposta Histórica"), Botafogo.

The Tijuca reforestation (1861–) was directed by Major Manuel Gomes Archer, who planted tens of thousands of seedlings with a small team that included enslaved workers. Today the Tijuca National Park is one of the largest urban forests in the world.

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Eight mental models to carry with you



Marc Ferrez, Panorama of Rio de Janeiro, 1889 · Instituto Moreira Salles · Public domain · Wikimedia Commons

1 Brazil is a South Atlantic creation

It was built as much from Angola and the Bight of Benin as from Portugal. Its people, music, religion and food — and its wealth — came across that ocean.

2 Export cycles move the centre of gravity

Brazilwood, sugar, gold, coffee, industry, soy and oil each created a new core and left an old one behind, with its elites and inequalities intact.

3 Slavery was the operating system

Not one sector but the organising principle of society for 350 years — and abolition came without land, schooling or rights. Its hierarchy outlived it.

4 Change by accommodation

Independence by a prince, a republic by coup, amnesty for both sides, democracy by indirect election. Regimes change; elites negotiate; structures persist.

5 A strong state for insiders

From the Vargas labour code to pensions and public universities, the state protects those inside the formal system — and leaves a vast informal Brazil outside.

6 Booms on borrowed time

Growth spurts have depended on external prices or credit — coffee, foreign loans, China — and ended in busts, inflation or debt. Hence the cycles of promise and disappointment.

7 Rio was the national stage

Capital for two centuries, it was where Brazil performed itself — court, abolition, samba, carnival, football, bossa nova. Since 1960 it has been a stage without the state.

8 In Rio, geography is class

Mountain and sea, tunnels and railways, hills removed and shores filled: read the terrain and you can read the social order.

These are deliberately compressed. Each can be unfolded back into the evidence:

1. **South Atlantic creation** — slides 9–10, 19 (SlaveVoyages; Alencastro).
2. **Moving centre of gravity** — slides 3, 13, 24, 37.
3. **Slavery as operating system** — slides 8, 10, 18–20, 23, 38 (Klein & Luna; Nabuco's warning).
4. **Change by accommodation** — slides 16, 21, 32, 34. The counter-examples matter too: Canudos, the Cabanagem, 1964 and the repression after 1968 show what happened when accommodation broke down or was refused.
5. **A strong state for insiders** — slides 27, 34, 38 (French; Souza).
6. **Booms on borrowed time** — slides 18, 23, 31–35.
7. **Rio as stage** — slides 11, 15, 19, 25, 28, 31.
8. **Geography as class** — slides 5, 11, 26, 39–41 (Abreu).

A final caution against over-tidy stories: almost every turning point here could have gone otherwise — a regency that nearly lost the provinces, a Farroupilha that could have won foreign recognition, a coffee crash that brought Vargas rather than someone else, a 1985 transition nearly derailed by Tancredo Neves's death, an election on 25 October 2026 whose outcome was unknown as this was written.

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No AI-generated imagery is used anywhere in this presentation. Maps and charts were drawn for it from the data cited on each slide.

Recommended further reading

- Lilia Schwarcz & Heloisa Starling, *Brazil: A Biography* — the best single-volume narrative.
- Boris & Sergio Fausto, *A Concise History of Brazil* — the best short analytical history.
- Luiz Felipe de Alencastro, *The Trade in the Living* — the South Atlantic thesis.
- Herbert Klein & Francisco Vidal Luna, *Slavery in Brazil*.
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